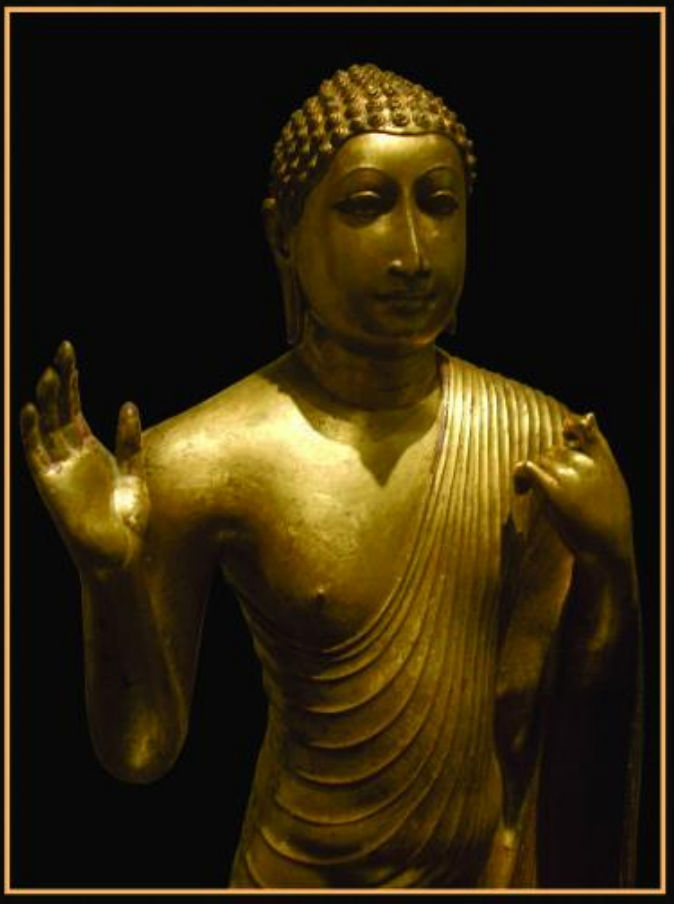
A Manual of the Excellent Man



Uttamapurisa Dīpanī

Ledi Sayādaw

Buddhism/Philosophy BP 420S

A Manual of the Excellent Man

Ledi Sayādaw (1846–1923) was one of the greatest Burmese Buddhist monks of the modern era, renowned throughout the Theravada Buddhist world as a scholar, writer, and meditation master. The author of more than seventy manuals, he became the "father" of the modern insight meditation tradition which spread from Myanmar outwards to the wider world. While highly learned in the Buddhist scriptures, he had the knack of writing in a lively, direct, and scintillating style, lacing his explanations of Buddhist doctrine with original and illuminating similes.

The present manual was written in response to a letter from a lay follower posing ten questions on important points of Buddhist teaching. The work begins with an explanation of the Theravada conception of the Bodhisatta, the aspirant to supreme Buddhahood, and of the ten perfections a Bodhisatta must fulfil to reach Perfect Enlightenment. The author then launches out into a detailed exploration of the "five aggregates" that make up human existence. He also gives coverage to the Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, the five kinds of Māras, and the nature of Nibbāna. Again and again, the Sayādaw impresses on his readers the need to take up the practice of the Dhamma in full earnestness, not remaining content with mere deeds of merit but striving along the path of insight meditation that leads to realization of the goal.

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A MANUAL OF THE EXCELLENT MAN

UTTAMAPURISA DĪPANĪ

VENERABLE LEDI SAYĀDAW
Aggamahāpaṇḍita, D.Litt.

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Editor's Foreword vii

Preface to the First Edition x

The Venerable Ledi Sayādaw's Reply xii

Chapter One 1

The Perfections Defined 2
The Perfections Explained 9
The Noblest Aspiration 16

Chapter Two 26

Seven Aspects of Materiality to be Perceived 26
Seven Aspects of Feeling to be Perceived 39
Seven Aspects of Perception to be Perceived 42
Seven Aspects of Mental Formations to be Perceived 44
Seven Aspects of Consciousness to be Perceived 47

Chapter Three 72

The Element of Deliverance 72
The True Peace of Nibbāna 74

Chapter Four 77

Two Types of Ordinary Person 77

Chapter Five 80

How to be Mindful while Doing a Meritorious Deed 80

Chapter Six 84

The Five Māras 84

Chapter Seven 93

How to Practise the Three Refuges 93

Chapter Eight 96

The Four Types of Buddhists 96

EDITOR'S FOREWORD

For Burmese Buddhists, Venerable Ledi Sayādaw needs no introduction, since his fame is legendary. Many Buddhists outside Burma will also have read his Manuals of Buddhism, or at least extracts from it such as the *Maggaṅga Dīpanī* or the *Bodhipakkhiya Dīpanī*, which are both published by the Buddhist Publication Society. As the name implies, a *Dīpanī* is a work that illuminates the subject, so we can call it a "manual" or an "exposition." The Venerable Ledi Sayādaw is deservedly famous for his expositions, of which he wrote more than seventy. All of them show his deep learning of the Pāḷi texts and commentaries, but this work especially urges Buddhists not to be content with mere devotion or academic learning, but to take up insight meditation in earnest to gain penetrative knowledge of the Noble Truths.

The Venerable Ledi Sayādaw was the "father" of the insight meditation tradition in Burma. Before he became famous, only a few monks practised insight meditation, and even fewer lay people. He lived during the time of the British Raj, when many ignorant Buddhists were converting to Christianity. At the same time, English scholars were studying Buddhism. The Venerable Ledi Sayādaw replied to some questions in Pāḷi put by Mrs Caroline Rhys Davids, who was then working on the translation of the Pāḷi texts into English.

The origin of this edition deserves some mention since it has been so long in coming to print. I think it was in 1991 that James Patrick Stewart-Ross, an American Buddhist, visited me at the Burmese Vihāra in Wembley, England and gave me a stack of computer disks, on which were more than thirty voluminous works by various authors. Many of them were by the Venerable Ledi Sayādaw. Mr Ross had spent many years collecting works by famous Burmese Sayādaws and had made heroic efforts to get English translations made. While living in Thailand, he made many trips into Burma, to search out able translators and typists to help him with this colossal undertaking.

within their own body and mind. The Buddhist scriptures wholeheartedly endorse the Sayādaw's opinions, so if you have any doubts, please refer to the Nakhasikhā Sutta, which he quotes.

The 1969 Burmese second edition, which I referred to occasionally, was full of quotations from the Pāḷi texts, commentaries and subcommentaries. Most of these have been removed, leaving only the English translation, to make the book more readable for those who are not scholars. Quotation marks are used, even where the source is not given, to indicate that they are not the Sayādaw's own words. Aphorisms coined by the Sayādaw are indicated by a bolder typeface.

In the initial draft, there was some inconsistency in the dates. Working back from B.E. 1359 (1998) 1261 should have been 1900, not 1899 as stated, and the completion date (of 1262) was given as 1901. So I asked a friend to consult a 100-year calendar. It turned out that the Sayādaw received Maung Thaw's letter on 9th March, 1900 and completed the work on 28th April, the same year! (The Burmese New Year begins in April). The Sayādaw had indeed been burning the midnight oil for an early reply. I have been working on this edition (among many other works, it must be said) for at least eight years, but the Sayādaw completed it in just seven weeks.

Preface to the First Edition

More than two thousand years have passed since the Buddha, the Sākyan prince who showed the path to nibbāna, the founder of the Saṅgha, the most exalted and incomparable one, attained parinibbāna. The Burmese capital of Mandalay has fallen, its king dethroned, and the sun has set on Burma. The country is now ruled (by the British) from London in England, a European land. Now, there is in Mandalay an association founded by a group of modern educated Burmese. They are conversant in foreign languages and devoted to the discussion, preservation, and propagation of the Buddha's teaching.

The Honorary Secretary of the association is Maung Thaw, a clerk in the office of the Inspector of Schools. A tireless worker, Maung Thaw discussed religion with various non-Buddhist religious teachers and debated some knotty problems. He recorded several points raised on those occasions. He wanted an authoritative decision on the problems, so he approached the Venerable Mahāvisuddhārāma Sayādaw, an eminent leader of the Saṅgha in Mandalay.

This Venerable Sayādaw found the questions profound and subtle like the ones put by Sakka, Lord of the Tāvatiṃsa realm, to the Buddha. He remarked that such questions deserved to be tackled by Ledi Sayādaw of Monywa, who is not only learned, but has led an exemplary religious life. He accordingly sent a letter to the Venerable Ledi Sayādaw, with Maung Thaw's questions, for solution.

Although it was usual for Ledi Sayādaw to reply to religious questions immediately, on the present questions, received through the Venerable Mahāvisuddhārāma Sayādaw, he took time to answer them. He wanted to be thorough. He considered the questions in the light of various arguments, collated authorities on the points he wanted to make, and added his own illustrations.

THE VENERABLE LEDI SAYĀDAW'S REPLY

This is addressed to Maung Thaw.

Maung Thaw's petition, with the Venerable Mahā-visuddhārāma Sayādaw's endorsement, reached me on the tenth waxing day of Tabaung, 1261 Burmese Era (9th March, 1900 AD). It contains:

i. matters on doctrinal aspects that need to be explained;
ii. an expression of your desire to train for the development of insight;
iii. a request to show how one may advance from being a blind worldling to become a wise and virtuous person.

A blind worldling *(andhaputhujjana)* is one who has no "eye" of knowledge (of the Dhamma); a virtuous ordinary person *(kalyāṇaputhujjana)* is one who has the "eye" of knowledge.

There are four kinds of eyes of knowledge, namely:

1. the eye of right view;
2. the eye of learning or scriptural knowledge;
3. the eye of insight acquired through mental development, which is right view on the threshold of supramundane knowledge;
4. the eye of right view or supramundane knowledge.

Outside the Buddha's Era, when the teaching of the Buddha has fallen silent, a virtuous person who has developed concentration and has the first right view, can be called a virtuous ordinary person. However, during the times of the Buddha's teaching *(Buddhasāsana)*, neither the first nor the second kind makes a virtuous ordinary person. One can be called a virtuous ordinary person only by gaining right view through insight, having understood the elements *(dhātu)* and the causative law *(paccaya)*, thus dispelling personality view *(sakkāyadiṭṭhi)* and doubt *(vicikicchā)*.

So, I would ask you first to read it alone. Only if you have followed it, should you show it to others. If you have any stumbling blocks, refer them to the Venerable Mahāvisuddhārāma Sayādaw, and not to anyone else. When King Bimbisāra of Rājagaha sent a book on the Dhamma to King Pakkusāti of Taxila, he added a warning not to open it in front of others. If you have understood my answers, wish to preach to others and would like to add quotations, you can ask the Venerable Mahāvisuddhārāma Sayādaw, showing him where you wish to add them. Otherwise, you may write to me. If there are any points that are unclear to you, write to me without delay.

Ledi Sayādaw
2nd Waxing day of Kason, 1262 BE
29th April, 1900 CE

A Manual of the Excellent Man
Uttamapurisa Dīpanī

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa
Homage to the Exalted One, the Worthy One,
The Supremely Enlightened Buddha

PREAMBLE

I shall answer concisely the nine questions posed by Maung Thaw, Office Clerk of the Inspector of Schools, Mandalay, according to the canonical texts and commentaries, giving my conclusions on doctrinal points.

CHAPTER ONE

The petition sent from Mandalay by Maung Thaw on the tenth waxing day of Tabaung, 1261 Burmese Era (9th March, 1900) contained nine questions. The first question was about the perfections:

5. Regarding the five aspirants: (i) a Perfectly Enlightened Buddha *(sammāsambuddha)*, (ii) a Solitary Buddha *(paccekabuddha)*, (iii) a Chief Disciple *(aggasāvaka)*, (iv) a Great Disciple *(mahāsāvaka)* and, (v) an Ordinary Disciple *(pakatisāvaka)*, how does the aspirant fulfil the perfections *(pāramī)* to achieve his respective goal?
6. May I know the definition, nature, and significance of the ten perfections, with particular reference to an aspirant to Supreme Enlightenment?

3. *Kāmato bhavatoca, nikkhamanalakkhaṇaṃ nekkhammaṃ.*
   Kāmabhavādīnavavibhāvanarasaṃ,
   Tasseva vimukhabhāva paccupaṭṭhānaṃ,
   Saṃvega padaṭṭhānaṃ.

Nekkhamma: Its characteristic is renouncing sensuality and thereby gaining release from becoming; its function is to purify and thus reveal the dangers of sensuality and of existence; it is manifested as avoidance of sensual desires; its proximate cause is a dread of sensuality through farsighted trepidation.

4. *Yathā sabhāva paṭivedhalakkhaṇā paññā,*
   Visayobhāsanarasā.
   Asammoha paccupaṭṭhānā,
   Samādhi padaṭṭhānā.

Paññā: It has the characteristic of seeing things in their true nature; its function is to shed light on all objects of sense; it is manifested as non-confusion; its proximate cause is concentration.

5. *Ussāhalakkhaṇaṃ viriyaṃ,*
   Upatthambhanarasaṃ.
   Asaṃsīdana paccupaṭṭhānaṃ,
   Saṃvega padaṭṭhānaṃ.

Viriya: It has the characteristic of diligence; its function is to brace one up; it is manifested as persistence; its proximate cause is a sense of urgency arising from farsighted trepidation of birth, decay, sickness, death, and all attendant ills.

6. *Khamanalakkhaṇā khanti,*
   Iṭṭhāniṭṭha sahanarasā.
   Adhivāsana paccupaṭṭhānā,
   Yathābhūtadassana padaṭṭhānā.

Khanti: It has the characteristic of tolerance; its function is not to be moved by likes or dislikes; it is manifested as forbearance in the face of the gravest provocation; its proximate cause is seeing things as they really are.

Dependent and Non-Dependent Perfections

The ten perfections can be classed as either dependent or non-dependent. Dependent perfections may be either dependent on craving or dependent on wrong views.

> "Something carried out with a desire for a glorious future existence is said to be done dependent on craving. Something carried out in the mistaken belief that purification of defilements is achieved through morality is said to be done dependent on wrong views." (*Visuddhimagga*)

A deed of merit done with a desire for existence in a higher plane or glorious existence is dependent on craving and is not development of perfections. Here, wishing for human existence to fulfil the perfections, as in the cases of the bodhisattas Campeyya and Saṅkhapāla, the two Nāga Kings, cannot be called dependent.

Some people think, "The practices of charity and morality, or merely taking up the life of an ascetic, are sufficient in themselves for the removal of defilements; no further practice exists." They regard their view as perfect. They sometimes acquire merit, but they totally disregard the need for insight knowledge leading to the path and its fruition. Their merit is dependent on wrong views and does not count as a fulfilment of perfections. Theirs is the type of merit sought after by fakirs. These two kinds of dependent merit keep one trapped in the cycle of rebirth. They are not called perfections.

Two Classes of Non-Dependent Merits

> "There is such a thing as supramundane merit, there is also mundane merit which serves as a seed for supramundane merit."
>
> (*Visuddhimagga*)

Since Maung Thaw's question relates to merit that contributes to the perfections, supramundane merit need not be discussed; only non-dependent mundane types of merit or mundane merit as the basis for the supramundane need be discussed here.

his wishes for glorious existence—two common mundane wishes. The elder brother gained enlightenment at the earliest encounter with a Buddha, in this case Buddha Vipassī. As for the younger brother, because his desire was not "nibbāna specific" but went off at a tangent, he missed his chance for enlightenment under the teaching of Vipassī Buddha. He attained release from existence only under the teaching of Gotama Buddha, after having missed the teachings of six Buddhas.

The moral of the story is this: when you are doing some meritorious deed, do not let craving for future well-being enter your mind. If you allow it, your wishes are bound to become your shackles. For the greater your well-being, the stronger your craving is likely to be, so that you find yourself dilly-dallying when the opportunity for enlightenment comes. If you aspire just for supramundane merit unencumbered by mundane wishes, then you can probably forsake worldly glories when you hear the Dhamma. So, Maung Thaw, you should remember that when you aspire for human existence it should be only to fulfil the perfections, which are required for enlightenment. However, don't ever let your wishes wander away to mundane attainments or well-being.

There is also the story of Puṇṇa, a householder servant of Meṇḍaka the rich man, who had strong attachment to existence as his master's trusted servant. So, when he wished for the result of his offering to a Solitary Buddha, he opted for service under his good master in his future existences! Of course his wish was fulfilled—he became his master's servant throughout their remaining existences together.

When Cūḷa Subhaddā, the consort of the King of Elephants (the bodhisatta), wished for the result of offering fruits to a Solitary Buddha, she sought revenge on her husband for an imagined slight she had suffered. Her desire was fulfilled in her next existence as a human queen when she successfully plotted the death of her husband of the previous existence. This spiteful deed sent her down to hell.

Kusa, the bodhisatta, and his consort, Pabhāvatī, both made offerings to a Solitary Buddha in one of their past existences. They had to go through a series of mishaps together because they made discordant wishes.

The same spirit of considering the deed alone, and not its rewards, governs the remaining perfections such as morality, renunciation, wisdom, energy, patience, truthfulness, etc.

Another way of classifying virtue is as follows:

> "Virtue observed out of craving for glorious existences and material well-being is inferior; virtue observed for one's own release is moderate; virtue observed to liberate all beings, which is the perfection of virtue, is superior."
>
> (*Visuddhimagga*)

Release from the cycle of birth and death, and release from the mundane attainments of glorious existences, mean the same thing. The second grade is regarded as inferior because it falls short of being a practice for perfections. Observance for the sake of one's own release is the perfection practised by the Solitary Buddhas and ordinary disciples. Observance for the liberation of all beings is the perfection practised by Perfectly Enlightened Buddhas.

THE PERFECTIONS EXPLAINED

I shall now explain the meaning of each of the ten perfections:

1. *Dāna*: Giving, making a gift or offering. Sharing one's wealth unstintingly with virtuous disciples of the Buddha is called sharing, or the practice of common ownership. The bodhisatta's practice of making gifts to anyone, virtuous, unvirtuous, or moderately virtuous, has already been mentioned. It means that anyone who calls at one's door for alms receives them. Herein, "virtuous disciples" means special people who deserve the enjoyment of one's wealth because they will share the knowledge of the Dhamma. With respect to such good people, sharing should take the form of respectful offerings after careful preparation.

2. *Sīla*: There are two kinds of morality; avoidance of the three bodily misdeeds and the four verbal misdeeds *(vārittasīla)*; and cultivating virtuous habits *(cārittasīla)*. The latter means paying respect *(apacāyana)* to the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha, and to parents, teachers, and those senior in age, status, or

The presence of such a tolerant frame of mind is patience.

7. *Sacca*: Truthfulness means avoidance of untruth and falsehood under all circumstances.

8. *Adhiṭṭhāna*: Resolve is the firmness of one's stand after one has committed oneself to something, whether expressed or not.

9. *Mettā*: Loving-kindness means wishing others well, with a heart filled with goodwill towards any being that one comes across.

10. *Upekkhā*: Equanimity is the quality of being strictly impartial to both well-wishers and adversaries alike. One does not behave partially towards one's benefactors. Neither does one harbour any resentment towards one's detractors. This evenness of attitude toward both the kind and the unkind is the essence of equanimity.

Here are a few similes to drive home the significance of the perfections. Patience and equanimity are the mainstay for the other perfections. Only when one has established these two can one expect to fulfil the rest. Just as a newborn infant can only survive with the care of its parents, the remaining eight perfections can only be fulfilled under the constant care of patience and equanimity. Patience may be likened to the mother and equanimity to the father.

If patience and equanimity are present, and the other good deeds are forthcoming under their benign influence, if there is an absence of renunciation, these good deeds will not properly become perfections. Lacking the guidance of renunciation, one is liable to be overcome by attachment to the merit derived from them and yearn for mundane benefits. Then the meritorious deeds merely prolong rebirth because they are dependent on existence. They do not then qualify as perfections. Therefore, if patience and equanimity are the parents, renunciation should be called the family doctor who takes care of the child's health.

To employ a different simile: all vegetation depends on soil and water for its survival; both must be favourable. Similarly, patience provides the favourable soil, and equanimity the favourable water, for the remaining perfections.

Equanimity in the present context is slightly different from the equanimity of the four divine abidings *(brahmavihārā)*, which signifies impartiality to the welfare of all beings (different from

deed was the practice of equanimity. Had he not been firm in the practice of equanimity, he might have left off there, and the heartless brahmin would not have survived long. Indeed the two principal perfections of patience and equanimity saw through the whole undertaking.

Saving the brahmin from such a deep chasm at the risk of his life amounted to sacrifice of his life or generosity. Again, saving the brahmin's life was the gift of life. Not even uttering a curse, and never raising his hand to strike back, constituted morality. In doing this noble deed the bodhisatta never thought about the merit he would gain. That was renunciation, the ability to forsake all forms of existence. For attachment to a better life hereafter is generally strong enough to spoil the perfection of renunciation. By not going back on his word to save the brahmin, the bodhisatta accomplished truthfulness—not very easy to keep under the circumstances. Lastly, fulfilling his commitment without wavering in spite of the brahmin's shocking treatment, was resolve. This was how the bodhisatta successfully practised the ten perfections in a single undertaking.

Regarding your particular interest in the aspiration to Buddhahood, this is a fairly wide subject. The detailed process of laying the foundation for the aspiration to, and the fulfilment of, Perfect Enlightenment is dealt with in the scriptures in fifteen catechisms. Only a brief account will be given here. For a wider knowledge on it, please see the Cariyāpiṭaka Commentary and the Sīlakkhandha Subcommentary.

The Three Grades of Perfections

I shall now outline the ten ordinary perfections, the ten higher perfections, and the ten supreme perfections.

All external objects such as a wife and children, animate and inanimate things, belonging to a person, are the objects through which the ten ordinary perfections are fulfilled. One's own limbs or head or any organs of the body are the objects through which the ten higher perfections are fulfilled. One's own life (being sacrificed) is the object through which the ten supreme perfections are fulfilled.

Regarding the Chief and Great Disciples, the periods for maturity stated earlier refer only to the periods after these Noble Ones had received formal recognition by a living Buddha. The Buddha predicts when, where, and under what circumstances he will attain which type of enlightenment. This is called "receiving the word" *(vyākaraṇa)*.

The scriptures are silent on the duration for fulfilling the perfections before such recognition or assurance. The interval between the arising of any two Buddhas is beyond reckoning. It may be any number of world cycles. A Noble Disciple (as the term signifies) can arise only when a Buddha arises or his teaching is extant. So it is important to remember that those durations mentioned above refer only to those Noble Ones who encountered Gotama Buddha.

As to the Noble Disciples: in the commentary on the Suttanipāta there are three types: (i) one who depends on confidence for his enlightenment, (ii) one who depends on diligence, and (iii) one who depends on wisdom.

The Three Types of Solitary Enlightenment

Similarly, Solitary Enlightenment *(paccekabodhi)* is also of three types. The commentaries say that the enlightenment of a Solitary Buddha is attained after fulfilling the ten perfections and the ten higher perfections for two aeons and a hundred thousand world cycles.

The Three Types of Perfect Enlightenment

The Perfect Enlightenment of a Buddha is also of these three types, which are also called: (i) *ugghātitaññūbodhi*, (ii) *vipañcita-ññūbodhi*, and (iii) *ñeyyabodhi* respectively.

A Buddha who depends on wisdom for his enlightenment, after receiving the assurance, has to fulfil the ten perfections, the ten higher perfections, and the ten supreme perfections for four aeons and a hundred thousand world cycles.

A Buddha who depends on diligence must fulfil the perfections for eight aeons and a hundred thousand world cycles.

That was the pledge that sent the ten thousand universes reeling and echoing in applause. That was the bodhisatta's earnest wish. For he intensely aspired to Supreme Self-Enlightenment thus:

> "Knowing the Truth, I will let others know it.
> Freeing myself from the world, I will free others.
> Having crossed over, I will enable others to cross."

This fervent and most daring aspiration is called "the Noblest Aspiration."

Eight Factors Needed for the Noblest Aspiration

For the Noblest Aspiration to materialize, eight factors must be present:

> *"Manussattaṃ liṅgasampatti, hetu satthāradassanaṃ.*
> *Pabbajjā guṇasampatti, adhikāroca chandatā.*
> *Aṭṭhadhammasamodhānā, abhinīhāro samijjhati."*
>
> *(atthasālinī; Buddhavaṃsa.)*

1. The aspirant must be a human being *(manussattaṃ)*.
2. He must be a man *(liṅgasampatti)*.
3. His spiritual maturity must be sufficient to attain Arahantship if he chose to (root-condition, *hetu*).
4. He must have met a living Buddha *(satthāradassanaṃ)*.
5. He must have taken up the life of a recluse or a monk *(pabbajjā)*.
6. He must have attained supernormal powers through concentration *(guṇasampatti)*.
7. He must have made the utmost homage *(adhikāro)* to the "Three Gems" while aspiring to Buddhahood.
8. He must have a most ardent will to become a Buddha *(chandatā)*.

If all eight factors are present, the Noblest Aspiration materializes. Herein "root-condition" means the four conditions *(paccaya)* and the four root causes *(hetu)*, which will be explained a little later.

Adhikāro means offerings, including his own life.

Chanda means a burning desire amounting to will or resolve, a preparedness for any eventuality. For example, suppose the entire universe was covered with sharp-pointed spikes, and suppose it was certain one could attain Buddhahood only by

The Four Conditions

There are four further conditions *(paccaya)*, also called the four stages of maturity *(Buddhabhūmi)*, necessary to qualify as a bodhisatta:

1. *Ussāha*—exceptional energy;
2. *Ummaṅga*—a keen intellect;
3. *Avaṭṭhāna*—steadfastness of purpose;
4. *Hitacariyā*——compassion, loving-kindness for others, even outweighing one's own welfare.

The Four Root Causes

There are four root causes: 1) attainment of sufficient perfections *(upanissayasampatti)*, 2) attainment of compassion *(karuṇ-ajjhāsayasampatti)*, 3) attainment of fortitude *(avihaññasampatti)*, and 4) attainment of good friendship *(kalyāṇamittasampatti)*.

1. Attainment of sufficient perfections means having sufficient perfections to attain Arahantship or Solitary Buddhahood at the time of the assurance.

2. Attainment of compassion is the endowment with a compassionate heart or universal loving-kindness.

3. Attainment of fortitude is a natural disposition for helping others. It is the abiding disposition that never tires in fulfilling the perfections. A luxurious life in the celestial realms is boring to a bodhisatta because it does not offer any opportunity to fulfil the perfections, particularly in serving others. Literally, *avihaññā* means "never being vexed." It also implies spiritedness. The duration necessary for the maturity of the perfections ranges from four aeons and a hundred thousand world cycles to sixteen aeons and a hundred thousand world cycles, yet the spirit of a bodhisatta is such that he feels he is going to reach maturity the next day. In other words, he is already anticipating Buddhahood that is forthcoming only at the end of such staggering periods. No duration is too long for him to wait.

4. Attainment of good friendship is care and respect in attending to the wise in all his existences, whether human or celestial.

leaves. However, those firm in their inclination to non-hatred soon dispel any anger, even if they are wronged by a gross injustice, just as a fire brand that falls on a stack of green timber does not start a fire.

3. Those who have no inclination to non-delusion do not like to listen to talk on wisdom. They never see even a glimmer of the light of the Dhamma, which has a luminosity of eighty-four thousand candlepower, so to speak. They are shrouded in dark delusion regarding the real nature of the five aggregates. Living in darkness, they die in the dark and let one existence after another go to waste. The darkness of their delusion is just like congenital blindness. How could one born blind ever see light even if eighty-four thousand suns were to shine forth together?

4. Those who have no inclination to renunciation do not like to listen to talk on the advantages of renouncing worldly life. Their attachment to the fruit of their meritorious deeds such as giving, virtue, or keeping the eight precepts, prevents those deeds from becoming perfections. Attachment corrupts them just as fungus spoils the choicest seeds set apart for cultivation, or as viruses, locusts, and other pests render a well-planted field infertile.

5. Those who have no inclination to seclusion do not like to listen to advice on seeking a solitary life in the forest. They are unable to tear themselves away from society for a quiet moment alone. Desire for companionship always pulls them into shallow friendships and ensures that they remain there, like a prisoner guarded by jailors.

6. Those who have no inclination to escape from the cycle of rebirth do not like to listen to advice on the emptiness of worldly life. They are under the serfdom of attachment to existence. That attachment does not allow them to aspire after the higher practice of the Dhamma leading to path knowledge. Instead, it keeps them satisfied with their parochial interests such as throwing lavish feasts, building pagodas, or donating monasteries and rest-houses. They are content with keeping the precepts, or remaining as devout laity, or as recluses or bhikkhus with virtue, or with some shallow achievement like teaching the Dhamma or writing books. These are only merits that hold them fast to the world, the wholesome kamma that prolongs existence.

3. *Kosalla*—proficiency. This is manifested in sound reasoning *(cintāmayañāṇa)* and presence of mind *(taṅkhaṇuppattiñāṇa)* that never fail him. Though the future disciples or Solitary Buddhas also have these two intellectual qualities to a high degree, they are liable to err occasionally. With the bodhisatta, these two qualities are unerring. This is the proficiency of a bodhisatta that makes him unique among other aspirants to enlightenment.

4. *Ajjhāsaya*—inclination. The texts treat this subject quite comprehensively concerning the perfections, but I shall describe it only briefly. Regarding giving, for example, a bodhisatta is very happy in making gifts. Whenever he has something to offer as a gift and a recipient is not available, he feels frustrated. Whenever he gives, he gives it with a light heart, and takes proper care in doing so. No amount of giving would satisfy his zeal for charity. Whenever anybody asks anything of him, he does not judge him by class or creed but always complies gladly. In doing so, he never thinks of his own needs but gives to satisfy the other's needs only. Refer to the Buddhavaṃsa on this, particularly the passage beginning: *"Yathāpi kumbho sampuṇṇo..."* [1]

In that passage, which is from the chapter on the perfection of generosity, "inclination" is described thus:

"As when one overturns a large cooking pot filled with oil or buttermilk to empty it, not a drop or even the dregs remain, but runs out of the pot, so also when a bodhisatta makes an offering... Whether the beggar is a filthy blockhead of a labourer with bovine instincts, or a drunkard, or better than them, a man who has taken refuge in the Three Gems, or one who keeps the five precepts; or in brief, whether he is good, average, or bad, let him come for alms at any time, the bodhisatta never judges what type of fellow he is, or whether it is worth giving him so much or anything at all; but never discriminating, never hesitating, [he gives freely]."

Of the different classes of beggars ranging from wretched to excellent, the bodhisatta never bothers sizing up a person who

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1. See p.16, §118 of the PTS edition under "*Dīpaṅkarabuddhavaṃso*," p.315 of the Burmese *Chaṭṭhasaṅgītipiṭaka* under "*Sumedhapatthanākathā*," or Vol.33, p.481 of the new Thai *Dayyaraṭṭhassa Saṅgītitepiṭaka*. For an English translation see *Sacred Books of the Buddhists*, Vol.XXI, p.20, §§118-120.

survive the uncertainties of the intervening dark ages. During those dark ages, right view is lost to humanity and wrong views prevail. One who has acquired only sham deeds of merit falls into wrong views, and so their little potential of merit is soon gone. Imagine the fate of one who repeatedly falls into wrong view for two, three, or more existences. This is the unstable nature of the merits of a person who has not struck roots deep down, who has not attained stability. Such perishing of budding merits is the rule with most beings. Innumerable existences have already passed in which they acquired some flimsy merits, only to be lost again by the next existence. This process of acquisition and perishing goes on in perpetuity for the overwhelming majority of beings. This is why the idea of "gradual maturity" does not hold. It would be a great pity if one depends on such a mistaken idea and goes on hoping for the perfections while actually longing for the inexorable cycle of rebirth.

The four conditions, the four root causes, and the six inclinations are the factors for declaring the Noblest Aspiration and for taking up the higher perfections.

On declaring the Noblest Aspiration and receiving the assurance of future Buddhahood, the bodhisatta at once becomes endowed with the five powers *(bala)*, the four special characteristics, the two qualifications of compassion *(karuṇā)* and skill in strategy *(upāyakosalla)*, the four stages of maturity *(bhūmi)*, the six inclinations *(ajjhāsaya)*, etc. However, since what I have said so far should suffice to answer Maung Thaw's question I shall not deal with any further details.

method is popular. In this treatise, however, I shall employ the Suttanta method only.

"Bhikkhus, a bhikkhu who earnestly wants to understand the true nature of materiality to eradicate the defilements, who habitually contemplates materiality from three approaches, who is proficient in the seven aspects of materiality is, in this Dhamma and Discipline, called accomplished, one who has lived the life, a perfect one or an excellent man.

"Bhikkhus, how is a bhikkhu proficient in the seven aspects? Bhikkhus, herein a bhikkhu discerns the true nature of materiality; he discerns the origin of materiality; he discerns the cessation of materiality; he discerns the practice leading to the cessation of materiality; he discerns the satisfaction in materiality; he discerns the danger in materiality; and he discerns the escape from materiality.

"Bhikkhus, what is materiality? Materiality includes the four primary elements: extension, cohesion, heat, and motion, and the [twenty-four] material qualities derived from them. This is called materiality. (1)

"As long as nutriment arises, materiality arises. Once nutriment is exhausted, materiality ceases. This is the origin and cessation of materiality. (2, 3)

"What is the practice leading to the cessation of materiality? It is the Noble Eightfold Path taught by me: right view, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right concentration. These eight constitute the path. (4)

"The pleasure and joy arising dependent on materiality constitute the satisfaction in materiality. (5)

"The transience, unsatisfactoriness, and instability of materiality constitute the danger in materiality. (6)

"The abandonment of desire and lust for materiality constitute the escape from materiality." (7)

(*Sattaṭṭhāna Sutta, Khandhavagga, Saṃyuttanikāya*)

If one can penetrate conceptions about the four primary elements and realize their ultimate nature, then one is said to be proficient in materiality, the first aspect of discernment.

2. The Five Sense Bases

The eye, ear, nose, and tongue are the sense bases through which the respective kinds of sense-consciousness arises. Body-sensitivity has for its basis the whole body externally and internally. These are the kamma-conditioned material qualities or internal sense bases.

3. The Five Sense Objects

The five sense objects should need no explanation. Only that of touch may be commented on as that pertaining to the primary elements of extension, heat, and motion.[1] These three primary elements are the tangible sense objects.

4. The Material Qualities of Sex

i. The material quality of femininity, which governs a person's whole body, distinguishing her as a woman or imparting the condition of being female.
ii. The material quality of masculinity, which governs a person's whole body, distinguishing him as a man or imparting the condition of being male.

5. Vitality

The vitality that gives a being its life, or the vitality of the kamma-originated materiality, that pervades the whole body.

6. The Material Base of Consciousness

The material base of consciousness or the mind is called the heart-base. It is the source from which kind thoughts or unkind thoughts flow.

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1. The element of cohesion cannot be touched. If you put your hand in water, you can know it is hot or cold, and you can feel its pressure. If you pick up a handful' you can feel its weight. If you hit the surface of water with your hand, you can feel its hardness. However, you cannot feel its cohesion *(ed.)*

probably comprehend things quite vividly. I am impressing it on you in various ways because it is elusive.

This first aspect needs to be properly perceived whereby the primary elements become clear in their ultimate sense, without confusing them with the collective concept. One cannot stress this too strongly because the remaining aspects will not be discerned unless you have the first one well and truly within your grasp. So spare no pains to perceive it.

The Origin and Cessation of Materiality

These are the second and third aspects to be perceived. Constant arising is called "*samudaya*." Cessation or vanishing, is called "*nirodha*." *Samudaya* is used in two senses: first to refer to the constant arising of phenomena throughout a given existence; and second to refer to the arising of another existence when the present one ends.

Nirodha is also used in two senses: the constant cessation of phenomena throughout a given existence, and the final cessation of all phenomena when one attains parinibbāna, where there is no more fresh existence and one escapes from the cycle of rebirth. This is also called *nibbāna nirodha*.

Nutriment *(āhāra)* is the sustenance of existence. It is of two kinds: physical nutriment and mental nutriment. Physical nutriment is the material quality of nutrition. Mental nutriment means contact, volition, and consciousness.

> "The past kamma that accompanies one throughout the cycle of rebirth is comparable to a field, rebirth-consciousness is like the seed-grain, the craving that accompanies kamma is like the fertility of the soil—*kammaṃ khettaṃ viññāṇaṃ bījaṃ taṇhā sineho*."

In the above quotation, kamma is the mental nutriment of volition, rebirth-consciousness is the nutriment of consciousness, which provides the seed for a new existence at rebirth, leading to a new material aggregate, i.e. the body.

In lighting a candle, the light appears simultaneously with the flame. Similarly, at rebirth, materiality appears the instant

Preconceived notions about what the eye sees obstruct perception. Expel these preconceptions with insight. Even in an ordinary flame (not distinguished by colour) constant change is observable if one looks closely. Every motion represents change—change from the old to the new. As the new arises, the old vanishes. The arising of the new must be understood as samudaya—the vanishing of the old is *nirodha*.

The temperature-originated materiality that is the body, which will remain when a person dies, is just like the lamp and the wick in our simile. The kamma-originated materiality, the consciousness-originated materiality, and the nutriment-originated materiality, which combine to give the illusion of a person, are like the man-size flame. The daily food intake is like the daily refuelling.

Our body gets the calories it needs from the food that we take. As the food gets assimilated, the fine materiality in our body gets reduced. When food intake is discontinued and nutrition is exhausted, the fine materiality and the kamma-originated materiality that constitute the body cease to function. All the different physical phenomena that constitute the body are totally dependent on nutrition. The exhaustion of nutrition from the previous meal and the cessation of the older materiality go together, just as they had arisen together. The arising of nutrition from a later meal and the arising of the new materiality also coincide.

If you contemplate the enormous struggle of all living beings to obtain food, you will realize the startling rate at which materiality changes in all living things. Then the manner in which one sustains oneself from the moment of birth, seeking to extend one's life with food, will become evident. As one can visualize the changing colours of the flame after refuelling with different fuel, try to visualize the exhaustion of a fresh meal's nutriment with the consequent changes in materiality. Focus on the changes that take place from moment to moment. The arising of fresh materiality as you eat, and the feeling of well-being experienced, like the gathering of clouds, is the appearance of a new lease of life, called samudaya. The gradual dwindling away of vigour after five or six hours, when the nutriment has been consumed, is called nirodha.

gathering of clouds. Then at once, the disappearance of those same phenomena is perceived, like clouds being wafted away by the wind. This is the function of right view. The focusing of attention on directly observable phenomena is the function of right thought. It is only with the appropriate application of right thought that right view can clearly discern the true nature of phenomena. In fact, such perception can occur in any posture for, whether you notice it or not, phenomena arise and vanish all the time.

Once right view and right thought are established as supramundane insight, three factors mature that can remove all bodily and verbal misconduct, for which the latent tendency has accumulated. These three factors are right speech, right action, and right livelihood. Then, right effort means zeal in one's undertaking. It also goes by the name "*ātappa*," which means "that which harasses the defilements." Another name for right effort is *sammappadhāna*. It has three aspects: *ārambha, nikkama*, and *parakkama*. *Ārambha* is promptitude and exertion. *Nikkama* is alertness that does not tolerate sloth, torpor, and indolence. *Parakkama* is vigour that never allows one to slacken in one's right efforts. It is due to the lack of this kind of effort that people do not attain to jhāna and path knowledge.

Right mindfulness means the constant awareness that does not allow the mind to stray from the object of contemplation even for a fraction of a second.

Right concentration is steadiness of the mind that does not slip off its object of contemplation.

These latter six constituents of the path are also each of two types, mundane and supramundane. Here, we are concerned only with the supramundane factors.

These eight factors are the Truth of the Path. Of these eight, right speech, right action, and right livelihood appear automatically once a meditator has achieved insight. The aim of insight meditation is to perceive the real nature of one's body in the ultimate sense, which dispels delusion. To develop insight, one needs right mindfulness, right effort, right concentration, and right thought. With these four factors as the locomotive, right view is ready for the inward journey. The right track for the journey is just a fathom in length: the height of an average human. This journey is

into its range, either apprehension or comprehension occurs, and a pleasant feeling coupled with joy arises. However, since we are currently discussing the aggregate of materiality, the mind will not be dealt with here.

The Danger in Materiality

"The transience, unsatisfactoriness, and instability of materiality constitute the danger *(ādīnava)* in materiality."

In the sixth aspect requiring proficiency in materiality, the transient nature of materiality will be evident if one perceives the burden of seeking nutrition, the arising and cessation taking place in one's body, as in the analogy of the man-sized flame. The daily struggle to earn a living, the constant care the body needs, the arduous acquisition of wealth, are burdensome, and these activities take place due to this body. When this truth is perceived by insight knowledge, that is right view.

Liability to disease and death, to all sorts of hazards such as fire, drowning, venomous snakes, wild beasts, evil spirits, or accidents that might cause injury or death, are all manifestations of the changeable nature of materiality. They are obvious to one with right view. This is the sixth aspect.

I shall now illustrate the fifth and sixth aspects. The British administrative authorities, in their campaign to get rid of stray dogs, used poisoned meat, which was thrown about wherever there were stray dogs. The dogs, being enticed by the flavour and rich taste of the bait, rushed for it, little suspecting any danger. The result is obvious. Herein, the enticing flavour and rich taste are the satisfaction in the poisoned meat, the hidden poison in the meat is its danger. This is an illustration of how pleasure lures the unwary and how danger besets them. Here the real culprits are the four external enemies: the colour, the smell, the taste, and the poison in the meat, and the four internal enemies: the eye, the nose, the tongue, and craving. Poison alone would not have caused the death of the dogs unless it was hidden in the meat. Poison hidden inside a lump of clay would be no danger because it lacks the attraction. If the dogs had no eye, no nose, no tongue, and no craving the attractive poison could not have endangered

The Escape from Materiality

"The abandonment of desire and lust for materiality constitutes the escape *(nissaraṇa)* from materiality."

In the seventh aspect requiring proficiency in materiality, the Buddha points to the escape, right now, from the clutches of materiality. When right view arises in one who perceives the pleasures and dangers of materiality, that is the escape from materiality. Those twin accomplices have been oppressing us incessantly throughout the infinite cycle of rebirth.

The truth of the origin of suffering is craving, which is manifested in desire and attachment to the body. How do desire and attachment cling to one's body? One believes, "This is my body; this is my hand, my leg, my head, my eye, and so on." Furthermore, when the eye sees something, one believes, "I see it." Likewise one believes, "I hear it," "I smell it," "I taste it," or "I touch it." The cessation of craving, which is the origin of all suffering, is the escape from materiality.

It is only when craving is present that new aggregates of materiality arise after one's death. If craving is extinguished right now, no fresh materiality will arise after death. This will then be the last death, for there is no materiality or no "body" to suffer another death. That is how one escapes from materiality. This should now be quite clear.

SEVEN ASPECTS OF FEELING TO BE PERCEIVED

The remaining aggregates will be explained only in brief.

The True Nature of Feeling

"O bhikkhus, there are six kinds of feeling: feeling originating in eye-contact, feeling originating in ear-contact, feeling originating in nose-contact, feeling originating in tongue-contact, feeling originating in body-contact, feeling originating in mind-contact. When, on seeing a visible object, one feels sad, neutral, or joyous, this is called feeling originating in eye-contact. Similarly, on hearing a sound ... smelling an odour ... savouring a taste ... touching some tangible object ... thinking some thought, when

body-contact" arise, wherever the contact is made. When the contact disappears, the feeling ceases totally. When some idea arises in the mind, "feelings originating in mind-contact" arise. When the mind stops thinking of the idea, the feelings cease at once.

The above six kinds of feeling are always being experienced at their respective sense bases. However, those lacking in right view take them not just as feelings, but as "I see it," "I hear it," etc. This is the tenacious, mistaken view called "personality view" or "ego-belief" *(sakkāyadiṭṭhi)*. When pleasant feelings arise, the average deluded person thinks, "I feel fine." When unpleasant feelings arise, they think, "I feel depressed." Thus the ego is always assumed to exist with respect to all feelings that arise and vanish at the six sense bases.

Just as the microbes infesting a sore can only be observed through a microscope, so only through insight knowledge can one observe the six kinds of feeling rapidly arising and vanishing at their respective sense bases. All the six kinds of feelings arise due to contact.

From Contact Arises Feeling

When a sense object meets its corresponding sense base, the mind adverts to the external sense object. That is what is meant by contact. Only when the mind adverts well does apprehension arise, and only when the sense object is apprehended does feeling arises. Since the feeling arises only from contact, it is called "feeling originating in contact." It is like saying "Jack, son of Richard" for clearer identification. Since feeling has contact as its origin, when contact disappears, feeling ceases.

The Practice Leading to the Cessation of Feeling

What has been said about the fourth aspect concerning materiality applies here too. Herein, right view means insight into the aggregate of feeling. It also means penetrating knowledge of the aggregate of materiality.

From early infancy, one has learnt to recognize and memorize things. Beginning from "That's Mum," "That's Dad," "That's Teddy," to all the things that a child takes notice of—the time of day, the directions, etc.—the process of noting and remembering things with their names is what is meant by perception. Perceptions, of course, go with the six sense objects. A visual object can only be recognized and memorized by the eye, a sound only by the ear, and so on. Perception then widens to abstract ideas, skills, knowledge, beliefs, etc., according to one's upbringing, race, tradition, culture, and the plane of one's existence. The first five kinds of perception should need no further explanation.

Dhammasaññā is the conception that perceives the eye, the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body (as the sense base), the mind (i.e. concepts of good or bad, etc.); the sensations or feelings, concepts or perceptions, volitions or will, applied thought, sustained thought, effort, desire; greed, anger, pride, or conceit; confidence, wisdom; killing as misconduct, stealing as misconduct, lying as misconduct; giving as meritorious deed, virtue as meritorious deed, wisdom or attainment of proficiency in insight training; and so forth. These, and a myriad other perceptions, are recognized and remembered. They are not taught, but learnt from one's natural environment and imbued by culture and tradition. One born in a virtuous family is likely to acquire perceptions about virtuous things. One born in the family of a hunter or fisherman is likely to acquire perceptions about wicked things. Thus perceptions can have an infinite range. Contemplate diligently to gain insight into perception as a separate element within yourself and in others.

When a person says, "I remember" or "I know," these are usually just instances of a deluded belief in the existence of a person or a self when, in fact, there is no such thing. The truth is that there are only phenomena, which arise and vanish due to relevant conditions. For example, a leper can never see the carrier germs infecting the sores on his body. With the aid of a microscope a doctor can let him see the germs, ever arising and decaying. Then he should realize, perhaps to his consternation, that the sores are not his, but the habitat of the germs only. Similarly, when you gain

This body is like the train. The heart-base is like the boiler of the engine. Volition is like the steam-power, which motivates the moving parts of the engine. As volition arises, it motivates the various parts of the body through the material quality that is the element of motion. This motivating power is astonishingly powerful; it acts very rapidly, and motivates all the limbs in the required manner of movement. It is just like the train being pulled along the track by steam-power. This is how volition drives bodily actions.

The volition working behind speech may be compared to the whistle that the boiler occasionally produces. The volition working in the mind may be likened to the steam generated by the boiler.

Volition associated with greed directs its motivating force onto the bodily, verbal, and mental functioning of the body so that actions arise, which manifest greed. In the same way, volition associated with hatred or anger motivates the functioning of the body, so that bodily and verbal expressions and a mental attitude of anger are the result. Other volitions, such as initial application, sustained application, or energy, also motivate the bodily, verbal, and mental functions. They result in applying the mind to an object *(vitakka)*, or fixing the mind onto an object *(vicāra)*, or putting effort into a task *(viriya)*. Similarly, it should be understood that all wholesome or unwholesome deeds, speech, and thoughts have the corresponding volitions activating them. For instance, an act of faith is motivated by saddhā; when one is mindful, sati is the underlying force, and so on.

Those who do not understand the element of volition have conceit due to personality view. Self-view is firmly entrenched in them. All their bodily movements are taken as their own actions: "I sit," "I stand," "I speak," "I do this," etc. All mental activities are taken as their own: "I think," "I have an idea," "I remember," "I know," etc. The truth is that all our activities are just expressions of their underlying volitions. Each is actuated by an appropriate volition like the steam-power that motivates the locomotive. That is why, in the aggregate of mental formations, the element of volition is singled out by the Buddha from the other mental concomitants.

them all unwholesome. They are the underwriters for a passage to hell. They are stumbling blocks to insight. They are detrimental to the realization of nibbāna. They belong to this side of the ocean of rebirths. Release from those beliefs means nibbāna, the yonder shore of saṃsāra. Attachment to the deluded "I" in all actions is what draws you into the floods of saṃsāra. Abandonment of attachment to personality view means to cross the great ocean of saṃsāra.

This is just a random list of ways in which personality view, the darkest type of wrong view, deludes the average person.

Since volition is the key factor behind any action, if one can discard attachment to the nonexistent self in respect of volition, personality view becomes extinct. If personality view in volition can be eradicated from one's psyche, the other mental factors can never again be associated with the deluded self. That is why the Buddha highlighted volition in describing the aggregate of mental formations. The remaining mental formations should be understood in the same way.

Seven Aspects of Consciousness to be Perceived

The True Nature of Consciousness

When someone wishes to see the moon, he focuses his eyes on the moon. The moon's image is then reflected onto a sensitive material quality, which is the eye-base. The same principle holds in respect of other clear, smooth surfaces like glass or water where the image of the moon is reflected. The occurrence of the reflection at the eye-base has a terrific impact comparable to a bolt of lightning. This impact on the sensitivity of the eye arouses an instantaneous succession of units of consciousness at the eye-base called "eye-consciousness." When the viewer turns away from the moon, the image disappears, and with it the eye-consciousness also disappears. Then the viewer says he does not see the moon. What is called "seeing" is, in truth, just the eye-consciousness. "Not seeing" is just the disappearance of this eye-consciousness. Although images are reflected onto clear, smooth surfaces like glass or water, no consciousness arises because the materiality

when a limb is numb, we know it is painful, hot, tired, and so on. However, more likely than not, we do not recognize those feelings as the arising of tactile-consciousness. Remember here, too, the analogy of using a microscope to examine a leprous sore.

There is an ever-present process called "the element of apprehension" *(manodhātu)* depending on the heart-base, which is so pure as to be lustrous. The mind-base is a functional state of subconsciousness *(bhavaṅga)*. When a visible object contacts the eye, the impact is simultaneously felt at the mind-base. So when one is looking at the moon, the image of the moon appears at both the eye-base and the mind-base simultaneously. When the viewer turns away from the moon, the image on the eye disappears instantly, but the image on the mind-base disappears rather slowly. So too, when sounds appear at the ear-base, they simultaneously make an impact on the mind-base too. Similarly, smells, tastes and tactile-objects, while impacting on their respective sense bases, also make impressions on the mind.

Imagine a piece of glass the shape and size of a man. Imagine a crystal ball, set inside the human-shaped glass block. All sorts of external objects—houses and trees, mountains and woods, men and animals, the sun, the moon, and the stars—will be reflected onto the glass block and the crystal ball inside simultaneously. You could see, for instance, the image of the sun on the glass block and also on the crystal ball. This simile is to help you visualize the phenomenon of the mind-base.

The above is the detailed explanation of how the five sense objects appear at the respective sense bases, while making their impressions on the mind-base simultaneously.

Apart from those five sense objects entering through the five sense bases, the mind-base can also generate an infinite variety of mental objects just by application of thought. These objects are purely mental. Whereas the five sense objects must present themselves at their respective sense doors to make their impressions, the mind-objects need not actually exist. Whatever has been seen, heard, felt, or experienced can make its impression on the mind at the mind-base. The mind-base has an infinite range of capacities differing from one being to another. So the mind-bases of a Buddha, a Solitary Buddha, a Chief

Then, on getting that information, volition starts motivating the respective organs of the body to function. It expresses itself in bodily and verbal action and in framing the mind, thus leading to mental formation's part in the mental process.

So contact is the key factor for feeling, perception, and mental formations. However, it is not the key factor for consciousness, which is the leader of them all. Yet consciousness cannot function without feeling, perception, and mental formations. That is why the Buddha says that the arising and cessation of consciousness is dependent on mental properties. If consciousness is likened to a flame, then feeling, perception, and mental formations are like the light of the flame. When the flame goes out, the three die a natural death, instantly. If the flame arises again, the three reappear together. If the arising and cessation of consciousness can be understood, the arising and cessation of the trio can readily be understood. Hence the arising and cessation of consciousness will be explained further.

The Origin and Cessation of Subconsciousness

When a person is asleep, the mind is in a state of subcons-ciousness *(bhavaṅga)*. This very subtle state of mind is always present in a living being, hovering around the heart-base like clear water oozing from a spring. It is an inert state of mind below the threshold of consciousness. So it cannot motivate the sense organs to function, either in bodily, verbal, or mental action. It cannot advert to mental objects. The heart-base is an offshoot of the four primary elements. Its vitality and health depend totally on the vitality and health of materiality, because the four primary elements are themselves dependent on the nutriment of the body. Subconsciousness persists as long as the heart-base lasts. When the heart-base ceases, subconsciousness also ceases.

For example, a rainbow is seen due to the presence of rain clouds. Once the rain clouds are wafted away by the wind, the rainbow cannot remain. To give another example, a powerful deva, by his magical power, creates a string of highly combustible material as he runs along, letting the string burn as he runs. The fireworks would last only as long as the combustible string lasts, no longer.

the eye and the mind that take place. Personality view clings to a delusive "I" based on the occurrence of consciousness.

Just as darkness reasserts itself when a flash of lighting disappears, consciousness ceases and subconsciousness reasserts itself at the heart-base the moment the moon gets out of the eye. The "not seeing" is noticed by the average deluded person who thinks, "I don't see the moon now." Personality view makes him or her think so, of course. For had there been a "person" who had seen the moon earlier, that person should have died along with the cessation of "seeing." This is the delusion dominating an ignorant person.

The Noble Ones, being possessed of right view, see the truth as it is. As contact occurs between the eye and the moon, transient moments of consciousness occur that cognize the material object called the moon. This transient consciousness occurs with dazzling flashes inside the body, like flashes of lightning. These conscious moments are as fleeting as flashes of lightning in their disappearance too. This is how the undeluded ones see it.

In the example of lightning, clouds are not lightning, nor is lightning the clouds. Cloud is cloud, and lightning is lightning. With a clashing of clouds, lightning occurs for just that fleeting moment. The lightning thus produced does not go back into the clouds. Nor does it go anywhere. It simply disappears. Try to extend this analogy to understand consciousness of all the six kinds.

> "Like the occurrence of lightning in the sky, all things, whether mind or matter, occur in flashes as conditions arise for such occurrence. Quick as lightning, they are gone." (*Visuddhimagga*)

During a momentary blinking of the eye, seeing is momentarily interrupted. This is a practical example showing the discontinuity of eye-consciousness. Seeing and not seeing are quite evident. Just remember the analogy: lightning is lightning, cloud is cloud. Regard consciousness as similar to the phenomenon of lightning. Try to understand the instant of its arising, and the instant of its cessation.

By day, visible objects are everywhere within the awareness of the eye-base, so we are easily deluded into thinking that we

of mind-objects in the abstract. This is generally called "thinking."

Volition is the power that causes every action like the steam in a locomotive, steamer, or electricity-generating station. The heart-base is the power-station from where arteries and veins branch out over the whole body. Just as a power-station transmits electricity throughout the country along a network of cables, the heart-base generates material qualities of motion in the body whenever the impulsion arises. The organs respond to the impulse immediately. Whenever a fingertip or a small toe is hurt, the heart-base "knows" it at once.

These similes are just aids to visualizing the complex psychophysical process. The underlying principle is the main point. If one sees materiality, but the principle of elements occurring from conditions is missed, one is apt to cling to a delusive personality view, which will then predominate.

You should reject personality view in the light of the truth. Do not let yourself be deluded by the wrong view that there is such a thing as a person, and that "I" exist; that such and such are my concerns, such are my doings, etc. See the fact of psychophysical phenomena in everything within and around you. Try to visualize the interplay of psychophysical phenomena whenever any action takes place in you, from the slightest blinking to explosions of fury (if this ever happens!). If you are vigilant, you can perceive the amazing events that are just the incessant, conditioned occurrence of phenomena, quite independently of you or your wishes.

Apparently, this body seems quite solid, substantial, and unchanging. Its instability escapes our attention. We are apt to think a thing is not changing under two circumstances: when change is so rapid that we cannot normally notice it, or when the thing does not change by its very nature. When you look at the blackness of space, you never think it undergoes any change at all, because it is not a changeable phenomenon.

All psychophysical phenomena change billions of times within a blink of the eyes. Yet we barely notice that whole period of one blink, for it seems so rapid to us. This body changes at a staggering rate beyond normal comprehension. This rapidity creates the illusion of continuity, an inborn notion strengthened by nature. If sustained right thinking can be focused on the

supernormal dimensions is meant the power that can "will" the forces of the element of motion to come into play. Of the four primary elements, only the elements of extension and cohesion have weight. In a human body, these two elements together weigh about fifty or sixty kilos. When impulsion arises through the supernormal faculty or attainment of uplifting joy, the element of motion lifts the whole body so that a state of virtual weightlessness is achieved without effort. The body can float away as lightly as a balloon takes to the air. However, a balloon's flight is very slow compared to jhānic flight. This is mentioned here to show the power of impulsion, the inherent quality of the element of motion, and the rapid change in material phenomena.

> "Through the pervasion of impulsion, which is the element of motion originating in the mind, this body goes, stands or sits."

The element of motion may be compared to the blast of air exploding from the barrel when a gun is fired. It pervades the various organs of the body when volition to execute a certain action impels the mind. The material quality of motion arises at those parts of the body and the desired movements occur. It may also be compared to the steam that rushes out of the boiler in a steam engine, providing the motive power to the pistons and crankshaft.

Impulsion and its Functions

I shall now explain the function of impulsion *(javana)*. The boiler of a locomotive is like the heart-base, the steam-power is like impulsion, but whereas the steam-power pushes once at a stroke, impulsion functions in seven successive moments. Impulsion is a conscious process of tremendous rapidity. Its seven strokes agitate material phenomena in the body like a mine exploding in the water. However, unlike the water being agitated violently, impulsion is under the control of volition, helped by the specific material qualities of expression *(viññatti-rūpa)*. Therefore the movements of the body organs are deliberate, co-ordinated, and orderly. Impulsion occurs billions of times within a blinking of the eyes. There are various kinds of elements

after stroke, is evident on listening to it working. So it is helpful in visualizing the process of the arising and cessation of phenomena. Lightning is another useful example. The heart-base is like the clouds, consciousness is like the flashes of lightning that occur in series of threes, or fours, and then disappear instantly.

The steam engine analogy particularly helps us to visualize the bodily movements, down to the slightest movement of the eyelids, and the activating of consciousness that is constantly arising and ceasing. Not only bodily movement, but verbal and mental activities also come within its scope.

The example of lightning helps us to visualize the sparks of consciousness that clarify cognition at the six sense bases. The intensity of these sparks inside the body, their arising and cessation, are comparable to lightning. The seven strokes of impulsion are inconceivably rapid, so instead of following the text literally, for practical purposes, we can assume that impulsion occurs only once for a blink of the eye. This would be easier to comprehend.

With lightning, both its arising and cessation are evident to the eye. However, the arising and cessation of impulsion, with intervening moments of subconsciousness, is not self-evident. One thinks that the sparks are uninterrupted, because the arising and cessation of consciousness take place so rapidly. Actually, the arising of the impulsions is interrupted by inert moments of subconsciousness when the impulsion ceases. No practical example is available to illustrate this intermittent phenomenon. One has to infer it from the appearance of different mental objects at (supposedly) the same moment. Even while taking a step, various things come to mind. As each new idea enters the mind, the previous object of our attention is dead and gone. Each object is co-existent only with its impulsion. So when we consider the diverse thoughts that our mind wanders to while walking, we can see that the fleeting diversions represent moments of interrupted impulsion. Consider also the process of speaking. With each syllable uttered, there arises (at least) one impulsion that ceases with the uttering of the next syllable. Similarly, with the consciousness at the mind-base, each thought arises only on the cessation of the previous one.

feeling. The impermanence, the unpleasantness or unsatisfactoriness, and the instability of all four mental aggregates are its danger.

The example of the poisoned meat given to illustrate the satisfaction and danger in materiality is relevant here too. From the viewpoint of the precious opportunity of the Buddhasāsana, the carefree attitude of the multitude who are missing the chance even to escape from the four lower realms is a common instance of the satisfaction and danger in the four mental aggregates. Imprisoned in the filthy confines of sensuality, those ignorant people are constantly oppressed by their own greed, ill-will, and delusion. They have a stubborn attachment to personality view, and have thus booked their passage to the remotest depths of hell.

The dangers of the aggregates of materiality and mentality are both characterized by transience, unsatisfactoriness, and instability, but the transience of mentality is far more rapid. This should be clear from our discussions above on the arising and cessation of these phenomena.

I shall now explain the oppression caused by the transience of feeling. All people have, at some time, been born in the human and celestial realms, and also in the Brahmā realms. There they enjoyed the best of sensual pleasures and the glory of the Brahmā realms. However, being subject to death, which ruthlessly consumes every conditioned existence without leaving any trace, none can ever recollect those previous enjoyments. Such is the transient character of feeling. In the present existence, too, they are forever pursuing sensual pleasures, which cause them only suffering. This yearning for pleasant feeling is only too likely to continue for innumerable rebirths. Thus they are enslaving themselves to the transience of those pleasures. This is how people are forever oppressed by the transient character of feeling.

How, then, does the aggregate of feeling oppress sentient beings with suffering? Herein, suffering has these aspects:

1. *Dukkha dukkha*—the suffering of physical and mental pain;
2. *Saṅkhāra dukkha*—the suffering of conditioned states;
3. *Vipariṇāma dukkha*—the suffering of changeability or instability.

apt to be highly conceited. Perception fills one with preconceived ideas and biases. Puffed up with success, one is led into believing that one possesses the world when, in fact, one is possessed by the world. The satisfaction in perception pushes one down into the quagmire of sensuality, from where one sinks to the depths of hell.

The danger of perception lies in its transience. It is only when some agreeable thing is happening that the perception of well-being can be felt. Otherwise, the perception of enjoyment is not available. Sense objects are never stable. They do not please one constantly. Therein lies the danger of perception. For detailed arguments, what has been said about feeling applies here too.

The Satisfaction and Danger in Mental Formations

When you see a visible object, it may be either agreeable or disagreeable to you. This is "feeling originating in eye-contact." When you hear a sound, it may be either agreeable or disagreeable to you. This is "feeling originating in ear-contact." Similarly, smell causes "feeling originating in nose-contact," taste causes "feeling originating in tongue-contact," touch causes "feeling originating in body-contact," and thought causes "feeling originating in mind-contact." Personality view takes all those phenomena as "I," but right view realizes that they are merely phenomena.

It is only when same agreeable object contacts one of the six sense bases that pleasant feeling can arise. Only then can pleasant perception arise. The moment contact is broken, the pleasant feeling and the pleasant perception cease and perish. It is quite observable how you feel pleasure or displeasure through a certain contact at any of the sense bases. Observe them then, and you can probably understand their pleasant aspect and their dangers.

So, ultimately, everyone is hankering after some contact for which they have a fancy, some agreeable contact at the six sense bases, which they regard as pleasant. The world includes humans and also animals.

The Analogy of the Robot

Let me illustrate the arising and cessation of the aggregate of mental formations. Imagine a robot the size of man contrived by the super-normal powers of a man who has, through concentration, mas-

Imagine a mine exploding in a pond and the violent impact caused to the water. Apply the underlying principle of the explosion and the water, when some strong emotion arises. Doing it fruitfully is not easy, but that is the way. Strive hard. Success depends on three factors: the example has to be appropriate, the mental and physical phenomena must be observed as they really are (unbiased by perceptions of personality or shape), and the experience must be strong enough to be observed. For instance, when strong passion arises, its arising may be observed from a detached observer's view, and the example of the mine explosion brought to bear upon it.

As greed arises, the expression on a person's face can be noticed by a careful observer. The expression is the manifestation of the new materiality that has arisen in that person. In other words, the mental phenomenon of greed can be inferred from the physical expression. If one reflects on one's own mind, the arising of a new frame of mind caused by some emotion, like greed for instance, is only too evident. When the object of greed has been enjoyed (say, a delicious meal has been eaten), or when it disappears, or if one reflects on its disgusting aspect, the greed vanishes like the ebbing of the tide in a narrow creek. The vanishing of the volition of greed is quite evident. This is how greed, a mental formation, sometimes arises within a person and how it ceases.

A warning here: do not confuse the phenomena with the personality. Focus on greed as a distinct phenomenon, not as belonging to a person. When one volition is seen through, the other volitions can be understood. All volitions arise and cease in much the same way—conceit, malice, covetousness, for instance—as and when the necessary conditions prevail. It is observable when one's spirits rise and one is ready to exert. One sees the arising of the volition of effort, and the cessation later. Likewise with the arising and cessation of delight, or the desire to do something, such as, "I want to go, but not now," or "I want to do this, but not just yet," etc. The pure volitions like confidence, generosity, or mindfulness, and the acts of charity, virtue, or meditation expressing those volitions, can also be observed.

danger of death, is subtle. It is not seen with the physical eye. Its heat is not tangible. Yet it burns inexorably within us and consumes all mental and physical phenomena, which is obvious. This fire is far more pervasive and greater than any conflagration on earth. It extends as far as the infinite universe and it endures as long as the endless cycle of rebirths.

I shall expand on the analogy of the flame and the fuel. The flame in the shape of the human body is a composite of eight kinds of inseparable material qualities *(aṭṭhakalāpa)*. However, not all the eight can be called fire. Visible form characterized by colour is the material element called *vaṇṇa*, but it is not fire. The primary element of extension provides the basis for the fire, but it is not fire. What holds materiality together is the element of cohesion, but it is not fire. The motion of the flame is the element of motion, but it is not fire. The smell of any object is the quality of odour *(gandha)*, but it is not fire. The taste of any object is the quality of taste *(rasa)*, but it is not fire. The nutrition in any object is the quality of nutritive essence *(oja)*, but it is not fire. The element of fire is a separate phenomenon, which can be felt by touch. Most Buddhists are familiar with the above eight material elements. However, very few understand that each is a distinct phenomenon. Understanding them as such is important.

So, of the eight inseparable material qualities, only one is the phenomenon called fire, the other seven are its fuel. The fire is sustained by those seven kinds of fuel. As one contemplates hard on physical phenomena, the startlingly rapid succession of fresh materiality that appears is the phenomenon called arising. Wherever new materiality arises, the old materiality has been consumed. Thus all materiality that has arisen a moment ago vanishes. This vanishing is the phenomenon of death, which must not be confused with the phenomenon of burning. It is the function of fire to burn, but the function of death is to vanish after having arisen. The primary element of heat, which has the specific quality of burning, consumes or burns up the other seven material qualities, which always occur together. The "fire of death" (metaphorically) consumes not only its conascent seven material qualities, but also consumes the primary element of heat. The element of heat has the "burning" quality, as distinct

describe as, "My back is stiff," or "My legs are tired," etc., are the manifestations of rapidly changing materiality. Old materiality is constantly perishing where fresh materiality is arising.

Changes in the body due to food, change of season, illness, or cuts and bruises, are superficially noticed by everybody, but lacking insight, most people just think, "My body hurts," or "I feel ill," etc. The personal identification of phenomena with a vague sense of "I" always predominates for the average person. This persistent belief has the dire potential of pushing one down to the lower realms of existence.

It is only by gaining right view that this liability to fall into the lower realms can be prevented. Right view must be cultivated because personality view is inherent in most people. It is, so to speak, built into their very system. It can, however, be uprooted with due diligence. When a house is on fire, the owner of the house will be careful to see that every flame is put out. He will not rest until he has extinguished the last trace of fire, since even an ember can flare up at any time and consume the house. Similarly, if you want to be safe from the lower realms, you need to be diligent, constantly checking that personality view does not linger in you regarding the physical or mental phenomena occurring within you. Through repeated moments of right view, insight will develop, which is the only effective weapon against personality view.

The Analogy of the Fire-Worshipper

Personality view is not just ordinary wrong view, but the gravest wrong view. There is, for instance, the wrong view of fire-worship. When a child is born, the fire-worshipper's parents kindle a fire for the child. For sixteen years the parents keep the fire alive by refuelling it regularly with ghee or butter. When he is sixteen, the parents ask their son whether he will remain as a layman or become a recluse and take up the practice that will lead him to the brahmā realm. If the boy chooses to become a recluse, the parents hand over the sacrificial fire to him. The recluse then takes upon himself the duty of feeding the fire with the best ghee or butter. The purer the fuel, the more meritorious is the fire-sacrifice. He takes the sacrificial fire wherever he goes. He keeps the

This analogy is given to drive home the truth of the impermanence of all materiality, the danger that besets all living beings.

Try to Understand the Phenomenon of Death

In spite of the inevitability of death, most people usually ignore it. You should meditate to realize the omnipresence of death. Try to visualize the ceaseless burning of the fire of death in all the four postures: standing, sitting, walking, and lying down.

All the merits acquired in the past through giving, virtue, or meditation for calm, if they were aimed at prolonging existence, are futile. The acquisition of merit now aimed at prolonging existence in the future will lead to the same fate. The burdensome tasks that one undertakes to support one's present existence are no different either. All these efforts merely serve as fuel for the fire of death. This is to impress upon you the futility of all human efforts, however meritorious, aimed at the continuation of existence.

The Five Aggregates and the Four Noble Truths

The five aggregates, being truly impermanent, are unsatisfactory. This is the Noble Truth of Suffering. Attachment to the five aggregates as one's own property, or one's own self, and the craving for existence and rebirth, is the origin of suffering. This is the Noble Truth of the Cause of Suffering. The liberation from craving, which is the same as the escape from the five aggregates, is the Noble Truth of the Cessation of Suffering. The Noble Eightfold Path beginning with right view is the Noble Truth of the Path Leading to the Cessation of Suffering.

If you watch the waters of a river and contemplate well, you will understand how the cold element (which is only an aspect of the element of heat) merges with other material qualities and flows on, always changing. In the eternal cycle of rebirth there is only an endless stream of phenomena, the five aggregates of existence, incessantly flowing like the waters of a river, and no person or self ever exists. If the fertile element of craving, the origin of all existence, prevails in the five aggregates, this cycle of rebirth will go on without end, and no escape is in sight.

When right view arises and realizes the true nature of existence, supramundane insight knowledge extinguishes craving instantly. This extinction of craving is the element of deliverance. Distinguish between death and deliverance. Death is the voracious fire that consumes all materiality and mentality. Deliverance is the coolness, the calm, the peace, that allays and quenches the fire of death. This element of deliverance is unique since it is not dependent on, or associated with, any other element for its existence. Just as the sky cannot be burnt by fire, washed away by water, or destroyed by any other means, so too the element of deliverance, being extremely subtle, is not affected by the fires of birth, decay, death, lust, hatred, or delusion. It is the fire-exit or escape from the eleven fires that constantly burn all beings who have not realized it. Since it has no birth, there is no beginning to it. It cannot be identified or counted. Being deathless, there is no end to it.

> "This phenomenon of release is intelligible only by supramundane insight, it is indefinable, it is infinite: its luminosity surpasses the sun at its brightest." [1]

In the above quotation, "intelligible only by supramundane insight" connotes the peace perceived through attainment to supramundane knowledge. The reality of the fire of death and other fires such as lust, hatred, delusion, birth and aging, has to be properly understood, and the moment it is understood, its antithesis of calm, tranquillity, or peace is realized.

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1. *Brahmanimantana Sutta, Mūlapaṇṇāsa, Majjhimanikāya, Sutta* 49.

of one's own body. So one is still an ignorant person. One is unable to understand real peace, for real peace does not belong to a person. It is never one's own peace or the peace that one enjoys. Similarly, the elements of cohesion, heat, motion, greed, anger, etc., need to be understood in the ultimate sense, if one is to comprehend nibbāna.

Aging and death are common to all. If one thinks that one has grown old, or that one must die one day, that is just common mundane knowledge. Because of the dreadful, false "I" concept, one loathes aging as happening to one's person. One fears death only because one holds tenaciously onto existence, which one calls one's life. Overwhelmed by this craving for existence, one fails to understand death as a distinct phenomenon. Unless one knows it as such, one is an ignorant person incapable of understanding nibbāna. One can talk accurately about nibbāna only when one has discarded personality view and gained the right view into elements and phenomena.

The flux of phenomena, ever perpetuating the cycle of rebirth, is just a series of arising and cessation, births and deaths, that occur thousands of times within a blink of the eyes. The process is incessant and inexorable. Since the twin root causes of ignorance and craving are present, this incessant perishing of gross phenomena takes place, consumed by the eleven fires within oneself. At death, the process continues as a fresh existence in one of the three realms, accompanied by the eleven fires. When ignorance and craving are extinguished, then the mental and physical aggregates in that existence do not continue as a fresh existence. The extinction of the eleven fires is the escape from the clutches of death. Whereas the compounded existence of elements is conventionally called a being, when the "being" has realized the element of deliverance or peace, that element itself might be called the one who has attained nibbāna (parinibbāna).

Just because saṃsāra is beginningless and endless, one should not have any concept of time regarding nibbāna. Again, just because innumerable Buddhas, Solitary Buddhas, and Noble Disciples have entered parinibbāna, one should not associate nibbāna with numbers.

The idea of the endless cycle of rebirth pertains only to

CHAPTER FOUR

The fourth question asks about the way that would lead a blind worldling *(andhaputhujjana)* on to the level of a wise and virtuous ordinary person *(kalyāṇaputhujjana)*.[1]

TWO TYPES OF ORDINARY PERSON

> "The Buddha, the kinsman of the sun, speaks of two types of ordinary person: the blind worldling and the wise and virtuous ordinary person."
>
> (Paṭisambhidāmagga Commentary)

The Blind Worldling

> "One who has no scriptural learning, being without knowledge of the aggregates, the elements, the twelve sense bases, dependent origination, the foundations of mindfulness, etc., or the interpretation and discrimination thereof that can prevent the arising of personality view, is a blind worldling."
>
> (Mūlapaṇṇāsa Commentary)

The Wise and Virtuous Ordinary Person

> "One who is learned regarding the five aggregates, the twelve sense bases, the eighteen elements, in the original Pāḷi, can interpret it correctly, and can discriminate each item by means of examples, illustrations, anecdotes, etc., and has therefore gained a thorough knowledge of those teachings is a wise and virtuous ordinary person." (ibid.)
>
> "Likewise, one who has gained a thorough knowledge of the twelve links in the chain of dependent

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1. A *puthujjana* is an ordinary, unenlightened person as opposed to a Noble One or *ariya*. *Andha* means blind, *kalyāṇa* means skilful or wise.

If the virtuous ordinary person can develop knowledge to the supramundane level by gaining insight into the seven aspects, he or she is bound to become a fully-fledged stream-winner. One can then advance in the attainment of the path knowledges until one becomes an Arahant. All these are possible right now.

> "Bhikkhus, a bhikkhu who earnestly wants to understand the true nature of materiality to eradicate the defilements, who habitually contemplates materiality from three approaches, who is proficient in the seven aspects of materiality is, in this Dhamma and Discipline, called accomplished, one who has lived the life, a perfect one or an excellent man."

As to mindfulness of the Four Noble Truths: By the time the last syllable has been uttered, the five aggregates are being consumed by the ever-present fire of death, which is the truth of suffering. Remember the danger in the five aggregates: "The transience, unsatisfactoriness, and instability of materiality, constitute the danger in materiality (see p.37).

The nutriment that has been producing the aggregate of materiality during the utterance is the truth of the origin of materiality. The contact arisen from the mental object of the Buddha's noble attributes is the origin of the arising of feeling, perception, and mental formations—the truth of the cause in respect of the mental aggregates. The three mental aggregates and the heart-base are the truth of the origin of consciousness. As soon as the recollection of the Buddha arises in your mind, the three basic evils of greed, hatred and delusion are destroyed, which is the truth of cessation, or momentary bliss.[1] The five factors of the Noble Eightfold Path involved in impulsion, namely, right view, right thought, right effort, right mindfulness, and right concentration, are mindfulness of the Noble Eightfold Path. This is how the Four Noble Truths are realized in a single utterance while recollecting the Buddha.

The Three Characteristics of Existence

Remember our previous example of the robot. Herein, the mind-object, the Buddha's attributes, is like the mirror. This mirror is focused on the heart-base of the robot, which instantly receives the mental object and apperceives it. Seven thought-moments of impulsion flash out from the heart-base—seven highly-charged mental activities that cause verbal action to arise through its motive power, comparable to the agitated waters when a mine explodes in a pond or like the whistling of the steamer.

The example of the agitated water is analogous to materiality being agitated. However, impulsion is so inconceivably rapid that no adequate example can be given. The power of impulsion over all materiality in your body must be perceived in every activity. If

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1. Of the two sets of *samudaya* and *nirodha* mentioned above (p.31), it is the *samudaya* and *nirodha* of the present existence that is relevant here.

physical phenomena merely feed the fires of death will be clearly realized. Then the relevance of the analogy of the fire-worshipper will be fully appreciated. When the perpetual arising and cessation of all phenomena within oneself is clearly perceived, the illusion of "I" will fall away. You will then understand that the phenomena are never you or your self. The characteristic of anattā is discerned only in this manner. If lack of a self is not perceived, all talk of anatta is fruitless. It is not knowledge, it is not insight, it is not practice for mental development.

The Threefold Training

Of the threefold training, the volition that impels a person to utter the words, "*Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi*," belongs to higher virtue because it is a virtuous act motivated by a conscious undertaking to abstain from the four kinds of immoral speech. That volition comprises right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration—the three factors of higher concentration. Right view and right thought in uttering the words constitute higher understanding.

The Ten Perfections

Understand the practice of the perfections in the manner of the Noble Eightfold Path discussed above.

Regarding Dependent Origination

The second aspect discussed concerning the virtuous person is, in essence, dependent origination. Nutriment arising, materiality arises; contact arising, feeling arises; perception arising, mental formations arise; psychophysical phenomena arising, consciousness arises. Tracing the cause in this way by analysing the results is the Buddha's method of teaching called dependent origination.

As to the twenty-four types of conditional relations, I shall not give a reply here for these reasons: (i) it is probably too abstract for you, Maung Thaw; (ii) it is not useful for insight training; (iii) it is purely for the finer discriminations to be exercised by those who have attained to path knowledge. When you have digested the present answers, you may ask for it later.

The Buddha told him that the throne of victory arose from the accumulation of his perfections fulfilled, but what perfections had Māra practised? Māra referred to his followers in witness of his right. The Buddha was alone then, since all the celestial beings had fled. So the Buddha touched the earth to bear witness to the deeds of giving he had practised when he had poured the ceremonial water onto the earth. At that instant the great earth trembled and the skies rumbled, sending Māra and his impressive army helter-skelter. Then Māra accepted defeat and returned to his celestial abode. This, in brief, is the Buddha's victory over Māra Devaputta.

Victory over Defilements and Volitional Actions

On attaining the path knowledge of Arahantship the Buddha gained a victory over all the defilements. The volitional actions that manifest only in association with the defilements also died a natural death. Volitional actions, good or bad, are called abhisaṅkhāra, one of the five "killers." These actions do not germinate as fresh becoming when deprived of craving, for once the craving for existence is gone, kamma loses its potential to reproduce, just like boiled grains. With the exhaustion of greed, hatred, and delusion, all immoral actions cease absolutely. All moral actions do not have kammic force in them and remain inoperative *(kiriya)*. This is how victory over defilements and volitional action was won by the Buddha.

What remained was the five aggregates, which were the result of kamma done before the defilements were extinguished, and psychophysical phenomena due to the four causes[1] before enlightenment, but free from defilements since then. The existence of the five aggregates presupposes the results of past actions, both wholesome and unwholesome. This occurrence of results continued until the moment of the Buddha's passing away. Since the five aggregates still existed after his enlightenment, the effects of past kamma were felt. In other words, because the kammic forces of the past still remained, the

1. Kamma, consciousness, temperature, and nutriment.

Let us make an illustration. A wicked demoness who liked to feed on excrement and putridity possessed a good man. She drove him out of his senses so that the poor man was subject to her will, and he roamed about in cemeteries and such places to feed on excrement and putrefied corpses. After years of subjugation, the man was cured of the curse by a magician who brought him back to his senses. With the help of the magician's powers, i.e. by making use of the divine eye in a magic formula, he saw the demoness within him. He could now clearly assess the situation. He had conquered the demoness, but after many years of co-existence he could not drive her out at once. Besides, he saw some benefit of her presence; he could put her to his use. The extraordinary physical powers she had would be useful for his own purposes. He could perform miracles, harnessing her powers in the service of humanity.

The analogy is this. The demoness is like the five aggregates. The proper sense of the man is like the non-causative type of good deeds. Cemeteries and such places are like the three realms of existence. The divine eye, the magician's formula, is the Eye of the Dhamma. Continued upkeep of the demoness within is like the continued existence of the Buddha, which could not cease at once because it was his long-cherished wish to help the multitude in their struggle for release from suffering. In fact, the Buddha and the Noble Ones, after attaining Arahantship, live on only for the good of others.

This is how the subcommentary explains the Buddha's victories over the aggregates and death even at the time of his enlightenment.

The Five Māras Defined

1. *Māra Devaputta*: explained above.
2. *Kilesa–Māra* : The basic defilements are greed, hatred, and delusion.
3. *Abhisaṅkhāra–Māra*: The ten moral kammas and the ten immoral kammas. It also includes all volitional actions that are dependent on the cycle of rebirth such as giving, virtue, meditation, reverence, sharing one's merits, rejoicing in the merits of others, etc.

causative merit, inevitably cause new existences. The aggregates of existence thus produced have death as an inherent factor. Not only is the fire of death inherent, so too are the defilements, the "destroyers." That is why merits and demerits are called *abhisaṅkhārā*, the "destroyers." The five aggregates, being subject to decay, destroy the life-faculty. By harbouring the defilements, they cause the destruction of virtue and the aspiration to non-causative merit. This is how the five māras destroy.

How Defilements Destroy

To put it in a different way, take greed, for instance. Greed in a bhikkhu destroys his precepts, his dignified training, his nobility. Greed in a layman destroys his morality, his dignity, and his reputation. Again, greed in a bhikkhu destroys the real well-being of a bhikkhu that lies in forsaking worldly interests and possessions. It destroys the attainments in concentration and spiritual powers. Greed in a layman causes undue loss of property, and even loss of life, limbs or sense organs, or premature death. All these evils befall one who succumbs to greed. It is similar with hatred or anger.

In another sense, greed destroys generosity, hatred destroys kindness, delusion destroys wisdom. All the generosity practised over aeons of previous existences can be brought to nothing when one is overwhelmed by greed. Hatred and other defilements are the same. In the present existence too, occasional purity of the mind due to hearing (or reading) the Dhamma is destroyed in no time by greed. It is just like the darkness of night that nullifies all lightning flashes, however frequently they might occur. Understand the evils of hatred and other defilements likewise. This is how the defilements destroy all that is pure and virtuous in living beings.

How the Aggregates Destroy

The destructive nature of the five aggregates should be observed within oneself. Try to visualize the destruction of one of the four primary elements that you call your head. Similarly, observe your eye, ear, nose, cheek, teeth, tongue, mouth and throat, then down into your lungs and heart, etc.

concentrate on the phenomenon of death, and don't let any personality view creep in. Don't associate your false "self" with either the phenomena of "the consumer" or "the consumed" (the five aggregates).

The Example of the Magic Pill

I shall illustrate the swiftness of change taking place in the five aggregates. Let us say there is a charm in the form of a pill. The pills are coloured white, red, black, etc. On throwing one—say, a white one—accompanied by the appropriate incantation, an apparition the size and weight of a man suddenly appears. It is completely white. Then, another pill—this time a red one—accompanied by the appropriate incantation, is thrown into the heart-base of the apparition. Suddenly the red colour permeates the whole body of the apparition, beginning from the heart. Wherever red takes over, the previous white vanishes, and no white can be seen. The apparition is now completely red. The colour distinction is to help visualize the change that takes place. Concentrate on the merging of the red colour into the white and how the former white disappears even before your mind's eye. This disappearance or disintegration is what is constantly happening within us.

> "Though one should live a hundred years
> not seeing the sublime Dhamma,
> better is a single day lived by one
> who sees the sublime Dhamma." (Dhp 115.)

This is an explanation of how death relentlessly destroys the life-sustaining materiality from the moment each new existence comes into being. If you understand what has been said on the dangerous aspect of the aggregates, you should find no difficulty in understanding the destructiveness that is the aggregates and death.

As to the difference in the aggregates of the Buddha before and after enlightenment: before enlightenment the five aggregates of the bodhisatta contained stains of defilements and putridity of kammic actions, while after enlightenment no trace of these stains and putridity remained. The body of one who is still training to

CHAPTER SEVEN

The seventh question was, "I would like to know the method of taking refuge in the Three Gems."

HOW TO PRACTISE THE THREE REFUGES

I am not going to describe the Three Gems in detail because they have been well explained in such books as the Saraṇādi-vinicchaya. Only the main points will be shown here.

People often think, "If I worship this teaching, it will free me from the lower realms." If these meditations have the merit needed to avoid the lower realms, then they may be called refuges. Some believe that meditating on this or that teaching will bring enough merit to avoid the lower realms. This kind of worship cannot bring such merit. It is useless. Those who believe in those teachings are not a refuge and are not worthy of respect. They are also not able to find a refuge. You must understand this while taking refuge.

To give a simile: the purified attributes of virtue, concentration, and wisdom are like fertile soil; the Noble Ones possessing those attributes are like a fertile field. Worshipping them is like sowing seed in that field. Here, the volition to worship is the seed. One who is without virtue, concentration, or wisdom, and therefore thinks only immoral thoughts, is like dry, rocky land. Worshipping one like that is just like sowing seed on barren land. The worshipper's act (however reverential) is futile and brings no merit.

Nevertheless, there are sure ways of earning merit and demerit, modes of conduct that are moral or immoral, and happy destinies or unhappy destinies understood down the ages by the wise (whether bhikkhus, laymen, or recluses). Wrong believers disregard all these merits and demerits and declare that what is meritorious is demeritorious, or that what is demeritorious is meritorious. One with such perverted views is like a burning rock. One who worships such a teacher is like one who sows seed on a burning rock. Instead of gaining merit, the worshipper will be burned.

the physician, but takes his medicine brought to him by travellers. By taking the medicine faithfully and correctly, eventually he is completely cured of leprosy. The other leper lives in the physician's house as a dependent. He does not take the medicine because he finds its smell and taste unpleasant. He only enjoys the good food that is plentiful at the master's table. The result is obvious; his disease worsens day by day. Of the two lepers, only the one who was cured knows, by direct knowledge, the efficacy of the medicine and the true worth of the physician. The other does not know the real worth of the physician or the medicine he administers. He has only knowledge based on hearsay about the greatness of the physician and the powerful medicine he dispenses. The analogy is clear enough.

So, one who is training to acquire the proficiency in the seven aspects referred to above does not need to utter the words of taking refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha. He does not need to go to a pagoda for worship, for these are mere formalities, and not essential, as he or she well understands. It is only for those who fail to practise what the Buddha taught that the utterances and the acts of worship are so important. These "hearsay" worshippers may be Buddhists today, but they may change their religion tomorrow. Those who worship with direct knowledge would rather give up their lives than convert to another religion.

In the world, any wrong view can be dispelled by a knowledge of dependent origination. One is liable to fall into a false view only due to lack of this knowledge. It is vital that Buddhists understand dependent origination and the significance of the factors contained in the discourse on it. One who understands dependent origination may be called a Buddhist of the medium attainments. One who has gained insight into the seven aspects of the five aggregates is a Buddhist of the higher attainments, since this right view is based on insight.

One is a true Buddhist however, only when one has realized the Four Noble Truths. Such a Noble One is a "stream-winner." Why is only a stream-winner called a true Buddhist? It is because taking refuge in the Buddha becomes inseparable from consciousness. In other words, there is no danger of a stream-winner falling into wrong views. Compare this superior attainment with the attainments of the higher or the medium classes, whose absolute confidence in the Three Gems is assured only for the present existence. As for one with only the basic attainment, their faith in the Buddha's teaching cannot be called stable because they might change to another religion tomorrow, if the right circumstances arise.

A stream-winner may be born into a non-Buddhist family but will not be led into professing another religion even on pain of instant death. He or she would rather be burnt alive than forsake his or her firm confidence in the Buddha's teaching. This confidence never falters, but grows until he or she attains nibbāna. That firmness of conviction is referred to by the Buddha as follows:

> "Bhikkhus, there is no possibility for one who has attained right view to indicate another teacher as his or her teacher."

There is another passage that describes a Buddhist:

> "One is a satisfactory Buddhist, if one becomes indignant at being called an adherent of another religion, and is pleased to be called a Buddhist."

In other words, one is pleased to hear the Buddha's teaching extolled and displeased to hear another religion commended.

Only during the time of a Buddha's teaching is there the special advantage of taking refuge in the Three Gems. Only then can giving to the fertile field of the Saṅgha be practised. As for the teaching, it is only when a Buddha's teaching is still extant that the teachings on the aggregates, etc., can be heard. That is why a good Buddhist ought to know them well. The seven aspects referred to earlier, if understood well, make a sound Buddhist.

The firm stand that a Buddhist can take and thus meet any criticism in the present existence is the law of dependent origination. The main knowledge that is the safeguard against any other religion either here or hereafter, until one attains nibbāna, is that of the Four Noble Truths.

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION NEEDS TO BE UNDERSTOOD

I shall now explain the law of dependent origination. Please commit the twelve links to memory:

> Ignorance *(avijjā)*, mental formations *(saṅkhārā)*, consciousness *(viññāṇa)*, psychophysical phenomena *(nāmarūpa)*, the six senses *(saḷāyatana)*, contact *(phassa)*, feeling *(vedanā)*, craving *(taṇhā)*, attachment *(upādāna)*, becoming *(bhava)*, birth *(jāti)*, aging and death *(jarā-maraṇa)*.

1. Ignorance

Ignorance is the opposite of knowledge. It is synonymous with delusion *(moha)*. The mind is like the sun or the moon; knowledge is like sunlight or moonlight. Ignorance is like an eclipse. When the sun is eclipsed there is no sunlight. When the moon is eclipsed there is no moonlight. Likewise, when the mind is shrouded by ignorance, no knowledge can arise.

Ignorance is also like a cataract that makes the eye opaque and eventually causes blindness. Sensual pleasures aggravate the darkness of delusion in just the same way as a wrong diet or strong, pungent smells aggravate a cataract. Ardent practice for proficiency in the seven aspects is like the medicine that can remove the cataract.

steadfastly to gain the path knowledge that is right view. Once one is established in path knowledge ignorance is absolutely dispelled, and when ignorance disappears the remaining eleven factors of dependent origination also become clear. The Four Noble Truths are then simultaneously realized.

How the Four Noble Truths are Realized

Discerning the truth of suffering *(dukkha sacca)* in the five aggregates, abandoning the ignorance and craving that are the roots of these ills *(samudaya sacca)*, the direct experience of the cessation of the twelve links of dependent origination *(nirodha sacca)*, the arising of insight with path knowledge *(magga sacca)*—all these four realizations occur simultaneously. The three trainings reach maturity, the thirty-seven factors of enlightenment are fulfilled, taking refuge in the Three Gems is well established, and the five māras are vanquished. Māra, the evil deva of the Paranimmitavasavattī realm, the great destroyer and "Tempter," cannot confound such a Noble One. Even if confronted by thousands of non-Buddhist teachers, a Noble One will never be in doubt about the truth.

This is an exposition to underline the crucial importance of ignorance, the principal factor in the law of dependent origination. Although the whole chain of dependent origination is finally broken with the conquest of ignorance, the remaining factors will also be dealt with to understand them more clearly.

2. Mental Formations

All physical, verbal, and mental kammas done with a desire to attain a good life, now and in future existences, are called mental formations. "All kammas" includes the ten moral kammas and the ten immoral kammas. Immoral kammas are committed out of attachment to the present existence, because of ignorance regarding the true nature of the five aggregates. Moral kammas are committed out of desire for future existence, because of ignorance regarding the same five aggregates.

The Buddha and the Arahants, too, perform wholesome actions with even greater diligence than ignorant persons, but

Nowadays, modern surgeons and scientists, lacking right view, depend on what the eye can see, and putting sole reliance on phenomena visible with the aid of microscopes, propound theories about life and reproduction. Those possessed of right view, however, though the subject is not within their province, do not fall into error because they practise along the right path to understand the subject as well as they can. This is true even outside the Buddha's teaching. When the Buddha arose, they learned the Buddha's teaching and gained right view of a higher order.

> Right view at the elementary level is bound up with personality view. It is only through advanced insight training that personality view can be discarded.

This is a note of warning that rebirth, or rebirth-consciousness, is a really abstruse subject full of pitfalls.

The Relationship of the Aggregates throughout Saṃsāra

The relationship between the material and mental aggregates may be summarized here. Regard the paths of the material and mental aggregates as belonging to separate courses in a given being, each taking its own path of development. In the endless round of rebirths, the material aggregate breaks up on the death of a being, but the mental aggregates never break up until the final passing away of an Arahant (parinibbāna). The material aggregate has no sense-faculties, nor can it think about or comprehend things, which are the functions of the mental aggregates. The mental aggregates do not have any form or substance, not even the tiniest atom, which is the property of the material aggregate.

The Course of the Material Aggregate

Let us see the course that the material aggregate takes. We shall consider two cases, the flow of a river and the path of a storm.

The waters of a river, in flowing from its source to the great ocean, comprise the primary elements of heat and motion. The water undergoes constant changes in temperature. The cold in the previous material element of the water causes the element of cold

tion plays the key role, not unlike the element of heat in the material aggregate. From the viewpoint of conditional relations, it is called "kamma-relation." Beliefs such as wrong and right view and the other mental properties are comparable to the primary element of motion in the material aggregate. This is called "the relationship of means" *(magga paccaya)*. Each existence is the result of a volition that has a given effect. The element of heat, for example, has its effects on the proximate material phenomena in a series. This effect can last only as long as the five aggregates of a being last. As for volition, once the resultant consciousness has arisen, its effects can occur for innumerable existences. However, the kammic force may remain dormant for innumerable world cycles until favourable conditions occur. The results of one's kamma remain as potential both in the mental aggregates and in the material aggregate.[1] Technically these kammas form the "residual" type of kamma or *kaṭattā-kamma*. It therefore follows that the continuity of mental aggregates is uninterrupted. So one can say, conventionally speaking, that "the same" mental aggregates prevail, though hundreds of thousands of world cycles may pass.

This is a fundamental difference between the material and mental aggregates. No parallel exists in the material aggregate. Only the roughest comparison can be made. Even in the present existence the two are noticeably different. Try to observe this within yourself.

At the breaking up of the existing material aggregate, the mental aggregates take rebirth with a fresh material aggregate elsewhere. How far away from the old body can consciousness take its rebirth? It depends on the volition (comparable to the element of heat) and the other mental concomitants such as right or wrong views, which are comparable to the functioning of motion (i.e. the relation of means). The text calls them "the mental formations that have the power of casting out *(khipaka*

1. *Kaṭattā rūpānaṃ:* when the residual kamma ripens, co-existent material phenomena at rebirth are due to deeds done in a former birth (*kaṭattā* = having been done.) [Though the fruits of a tree are not literally "stored" in the tree, the tree is a potential source of fruits in due season (ed.)]

grows into a magnificent tree, from the moment of conception an embryo develops gradually into a living being (such as human being, etc.) as follows:

1. In the first seven days, as embryonic liquid (invisible at first);
2. In the second seven days, as a foamy substance;
3. In the third seven days, as a clot of blood;
4. In the fourth seven days, as a tiny lump of flesh.

Then at the end of the eleventh week, the head and limbs take shape when the four sense bases of eye, ear, nose, and tongue are formed. The two sense bases of body and mind arise at conception. This is (roughly) how materiality arises.

Scientific knowledge is limited primarily to what the microscope can reveal. It is therefore beyond the ability of modern scientists to observe the subtle material phenomena. Based on physiological findings alone, they can only define animal and human faculties.

5. The Six Senses

The six senses—the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind—are called *saḷāyatana*. The first five are included in the material aggregate. The sixth, the mind, is nothing but consciousness. Although the six senses are included in psychophysical phenomena, they are repeated as the fifth link of dependent origination due to their importance. They are the six main doors in a being like the main gates of a city. They may also be called the six head offices, the six warehouses, the six ports, or the six railway terminals.

It is through these six ports that the six kinds of steamships travel to the various destinations—the heavenly realms or the realms of misery. Similarly, it is through these six railway terminals that the six trains set out on their journeys in saṃsāra.

The Buddha said, "What, monks, is the arising of the world? Because of the eye and visible object, eye-consciousness arises. The meeting of the three—the eye, the visible object, and eye-consciousness—is contact. Because of contact, feeling arises. Because of feeling ... Thus arises this whole mass of suffering. This, monks, is called the arising of the world."

it, feeling arises. Here, feeling is like a withered lotus coming into contact with cool water. Feeling is enjoyed as pleasant. This causes craving or attachment to arise. Attachment does not let go of that pleasant feeling. No craving arises in the Buddha and the Arahants, although they know that a thing can evoke pleasure, since they see the danger of being attached to pleasant feeling.

For example, when an unwary person finds a poisonous fruit which looks like the choicest mango, and smells and tastes like it too, he will be enticed by the appearance, smell, and taste. However, someone who knows that the fruit is poisonous, far from being enticed, will laugh at it and scorn it in fear. This is how, on seeing some desirable thing, different reactions arise in one who has defilements and one who is free from defilements.

Pleasant feeling or attachment may be likened to the sticky substance used by hunters to trap monkeys. When one is pleased with the object, craving for the pleasant feeling grows, intensifies, and becomes rooted in the sense object. The roots extend deeper and take a firm hold like the roots of a banyan tree clinging to and creeping into decaying brickwork. (How this process of attachment arises will be dealt with later.) The attachment that arises from craving is called "sensual attachment" *(kāmupādāna)*.

Attachment arises immediately in one who is in the habit of falling into lust. If the object of attachment is one's own property, it holds him fast to the round of existences but does not pull him down to hell. If the object of attachment is the property of another, and one does not covet it, the attachment may not send one down to the hell realms. When, however, one covets another's property, this attachment is unwholesome kamma. Scheming to take another's property is an evil volition that amounts to a mental act of covetousness *(abhijjhā)*. It has the potential to push one down to hell. It, too, is like a train that will carry one to the realms of torture.

Further, if one bears malice against the owner of the property that one covets, it is the evil volition of ill-will *(vyāpāda)*. This also has the potential to send one down to hell. Again, if one believes that harbouring malice is not a serious evil, and that those recluses and wise men who say it is are wrong; that there is no such thing as kamma; that malicious thoughts produce no result; that the worse that could happen is that anger would arise in the owner if

of craving to prevail that naturally inclines one to harbour wrong views and personality view.

All the existences of beings in the human world, or the higher worlds of the devas and the brahmās, or the lower worlds of the four realms of misery, arise due to the causal factors of consciousness and psychophysical phenomena. This fact must be understood. These two factors bring about what is tangible.

The six senses, contact, and feeling are the three factors that manipulate and adorn the tangible bodies of beings. Craving and attachment are the bold banners of the ordinary person signifying the manipulation and adornment (by the three manipulators) on the body. Regarding the banner of attachment there are four kinds:

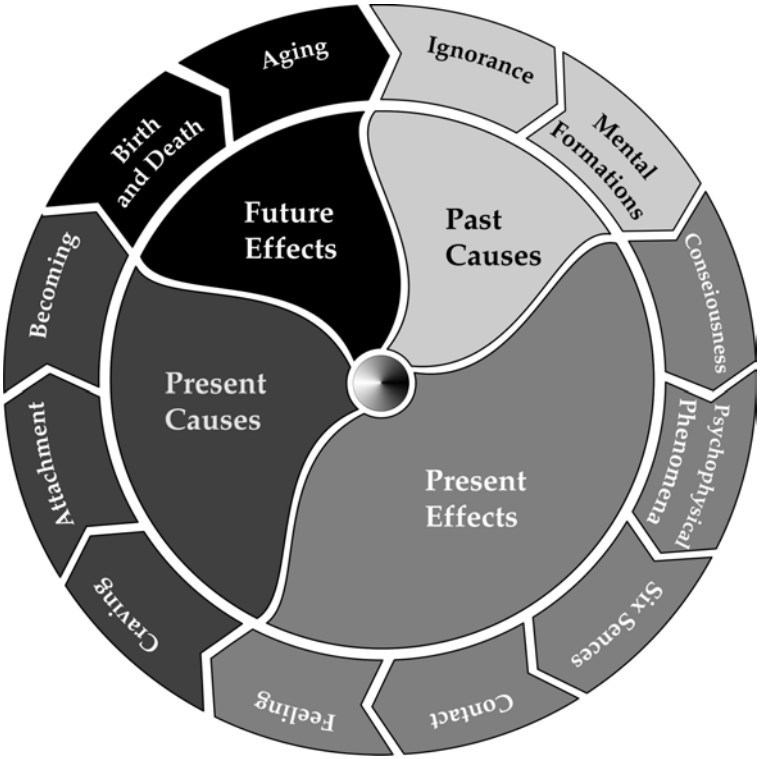
i. Sensual attachment *(kāmupādāna)*;
ii. Attachment to wrong view *(diṭṭhupādāna)*;
iii. Attachment to futile practices or rituals *(sīlabbatupādāna)*;
iv. Attachment to personality view *(attāvādupādāna)*.

i. *Kāmupadāna* means tenacious attachment to magnificent existence as a man, deva, or Sakka, the celestial lord of the Tāvatiṃsa realm, just as the roots of the banyan tree cling to the crevices in brickwork. It is, in essence, craving. It is comparable to Balavamukha—the awesome whirlpool in the great oceans, the dread of all seafarers. If sucked into the whirlpool of sensual attachment, one is dragged down directly to hell. Most beings are spun around by the powerful whirlpool of sensuality so that even when a Buddha arises in the world, they miss the rare opportunity to comprehend the Dhamma because they cling to existence so desperately. They cannot hear the teaching even now, though it is still loud and clear.

Craving, which takes pleasure in the six senses and their objects, may be likened to the peripheral currents of the great whirlpool, from which one could, with mindful determination, extricate oneself, However, if one advances too far into the currents, the whirlpool will drag one down. All seafarers, once caught in it, are sucked down into the ocean's depths. Similarly, once attachment has established itself in one's mind, one is inextricably drawn into the saṃsāric current and cast down to the depths of hell.

Some Difficult Points in Dependent Origination

The first two factors—ignorance and mental formations—are the past causes that lie at the root of the present existence. In other words, our previous deluded actions have "created" our present existence. Who creates all beings? Ignorance and mental formations create them all. There is no other Creator. (Ignorance and mental formations have already been explained above.)



What happens after death? Rebirth follows death. Rebirth is a fresh becoming. The eight intermediate factors from *viññāṇa* to *bhava* belong to the present. That is what is generally called "life" or "the world." The cycle of rebirth is without beginning. In that beginningless cycle, when you consider the present existence, it is

mental formations. This shows that dependent origination and the eight factors are knowable. It is enough to understand their past arising. To ask when previous ignorance began is as futile as tasting water from all the great oceans to know whether seawater is salty. The previous ignorance and mental formations arose just because there were those eight factors present in a previous existence. So to trace back all the previous existences would be an endless search. More importantly, it serves no purpose and is not conducive to attaining nibbāna. This is the reason for saying that saṃsāra is without any beginning.

The Dangers of Aging and Death

In all the realms of existence, aging and death are the real dangers. All animate or inanimate things that one thinks one possesses (including the body and the mind) contain the elements of aging and death. Therefore, one is subject to the dangers of fire, water, disease, poisonous or ferocious animals, evil spirits, and so on. One who has epilepsy is in constant danger of having a fit on hearing exciting music. Similarly, the constant danger of aging and death is inherent in all beings. Life-spans are spoken of because death is a sure thing. So we say, for instance, that the Cātumaharājikā devaloka has a five-hundred year life-span or that the Tāvatiṃsa devaloka has a thousand-year life-span, etc.

It is due to the element of aging and death that we have to busy ourselves with the daily chores of maintaining our existence, or on a spiritual level, with onerous meritorious deeds such as giving, virtue, training and cultivating the mind, and so on.

In all the planes of existence, aging and death are the only real dangers. They are the only fires in the ultimate sense. All the activities of each living being are undertaken just to serve the fires of aging and death. Every existence ends in decay and death. (A proper presentation of this point should convince any non-Buddhist of these facts.)

Q . Where do aging and death originate?
A . They originate in birth.

Birth implies decay and death. Where there is no birth, decay and death cannot arise. This is a plain fact with which

alone. "It is as fate (*kamma*) would have it," they would say, or "If luck is with us we may have something to eat," or "It is bad kamma that caused this misfortune," or "It is through good kamma alone that one prospers," and so on. Such exclusive dependence upon the power and effect of past kamma is not correct. It is a form of wrong view called "*pubbekatahetu-diṭṭhi*" or the belief that all is conditioned by past kamma. This is according to the Suttas and also the Abhidhamma.

Kamma is like seed-grain. Joy or sorrow (pleasant or unpleasant feeling) are like the paddy, making an effort is like the fertility of the soil, knowledge or skill are like the rain or irrigation water. The same seed-grain yields a good or poor crop depending upon the fertility of the soil, the supply of water, and most of all, effort exerted at the right time and in the right way. Indeed kamma is highly dependent on present effort. The seed-grain is no more significant than good soil and regular watering of a paddy field. Even the best of seeds, such as the Abbhantara[1] fruit's stone, will not thrive in poor soil and in dry conditions. A successful birth can result only when proper prenatal care is given and arrangements have been made for the birth. Again, present results also depend on skill, discretion, and prompt effort.

Some people lack knowledge and skill besides effort. They fall on hard times, too. No wonder, then, that they become poor. They blame fate or previous kamma. They would point to the exceptional cases of those lucky ones who prosper without skill or effort. In fact their knowledge about kamma is scanty and shallow.

Because one's previous kamma has been deficient in wholesome deeds, one may be born ugly, physically deformed, or handicapped. Such congenital deficiencies are the result of past kamma, which one can do very little to alter. Once one has been born, the matter of upbringing, personal care, working for a living, acquiring wealth and merits, etc., are up to oneself. This is present kamma, which depends primarily on one's own wisdom and effort. One's progress in the world depends very much on present kamma.

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1. The legendary mango of divine taste, a very rare fruit said to grow in the heart of the Himalayan mountains (*Abbhantara* = interior).

> "Whatever pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling one experiences is due to an Almighty God."

Certain teachers hold that there is no cause or condition for what a person experiences. Those who believe this maintain:

> "Whatever pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling one experiences is without cause."

Certain naked ascetics taught that pleasure and pain are the result of past kamma and nothing else. This is also a wrong view called "*pubbekatahetu-diṭṭhi*." This view is partly true, but it is still a wrong view because it rules out causes and conditions other than kamma.

The law of dependent origination says:

> "Body consciousness arises dependent on the body and a tactile object. The coincidence of the three is contact, and feeling is conditioned by contact."

Cold is felt in the following way according to the Buddha's teaching quoted above. There is the body-base inside you. There is the material element of heat, which can become cold (a quality of the heat element). This serves as the sense object, the tangible kind that corresponds to the sensitive body-base. As the sense object (cold) and the sense base (body) come into contact, tactile-consciousness arises throughout the body. These three elements of cold, body-base, and tactile-consciousness condition the mental factor called contact. This contact causes feeling to arise. Here, it is the unpleasant feeling of cold, and one might say, "Oh, it's terribly cold." When one approaches a fire, the cold feeling vanishes, and a pleasant feeling of warmth arises in its place. How does this new feeling come about? Is it God's will? Or is it purely a matter of kamma?

Similarly, when the external material quality of warmth contacts the sensitive body-base, tactile-consciousness arises. Consciousness arises dependent on the body, so it is called tactile-consciousness. This, in turn, causes feeling born of body-contact *(kāya-samphassajā-vedanā)* to arise. The vanishing of the external cold material quality leads to the vanishing of the tactile-consciousness and of the cold feeling thus produced. When one

THE FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS EXPLAINED

Everyone normally seeks safety, and strives for well-being. All mundane activities are aimed at avoiding discomfort and enjoying pleasure in some way or other. No one wants to get into trouble. No one knowingly tries to hurt himself. Everyone wants to enjoy pleasure and is striving towards that end. Although everyone wants pleasure and happiness and fears pain and sorrow, few know what really ails the world, or what real happiness is.

The Real Ill is Aging and Death

The main ill in the world is aging and death. The danger of death and how it destroys all existences has already been discussed at length and illustrated by the examples of the fire-worshippers and the spendthrift wife. Aging paves the way for death. So whatever illustrations we have used concerning death also apply to aging.

Wherever an ordinary person is born, two hell fires are burning within. One is personality view and the other is doubt (about the Four Noble Truths). Aging and death are the agents in the service of the two fires. They destroy one who is attached to existence, as all beings are. When they have completed their mission of destruction and a being breaks up into the constituent aggregates, the two fires of personality view and doubt cast that being down into hell. They can seize this opportunity only at the breaking up of the five aggregates. The two fires burn within all individuals, even if they are born in one of the six deva realms or in the brahmā realms.

The Buddha said, "Through not understanding this law of dependent origination, Ānanda, these beings are all confused in their existences, like a spoilt skein, or like a weaver bird's nest, or like dried *muñja* grass. They cannot escape from falling into the realms of misery, all in disarray."

The Danger of Falling in Disarray

If you ask someone, "Where will you be born after death?" the reply will probably be, "I don't know; it depends on my kamma."

notion of a self, one is cast down by kamma and falls in disarray. The same thing happens in the deva and brahmā realms as well, and this has been happening since the dawn of time. This complete helplessness at death, when one's kamma usually casts one down into the four realms of misery, is called "*vinipāta*." This is the law of kamma that governs all ordinary persons.

This danger besets the multitude. Its danger and relentlessness during one's lifetime should be understood from the analogies of the fire-worshipper and the spendthrift wife. Aging and death not only destroy, but they also send one to hell because of one's attachment to personality view. All beings are subject to the misfortunes of decay and death, and all have the fires of hell burning within them. That is why all existences are simply dreadful—*dukkha*.

The Present Dangers of Decay and Death

I shall now explain the evils of decay and death to which one is subject during one's lifetime. Since one's birth there has not been a single moment, not so much as a single breath, when one was free from the danger of death. Death is lurking from the time a being is born, and it has always been like this. Mortality keeps beings in constant danger, for there are any number of ways to die. For instance, food is not normally poisonous. However, food can cause an allergic reaction. Though you choose some delicacy to pamper your palate, on eating it you may suddenly become ill and die. Death has countless ways to fulfil its mission. Why should good food turn deadly? Why should this happen to anyone? It is simply because there is a disease in beings (aging, in the ultimate sense) that is always faithfully aiding death. This is just one example of how death can overtake us at any moment. If there was no danger of death, one need not fear anything, not even a thunderbolt striking one's head.

All human endeavours such as earning a livelihood, living in organized society, maintaining law and order, protecting oneself, one's property, etc., are primarily aimed at self-preservation. This, in simple terms, is an attempt to ward off the dangers of death. The danger of death is also a motivating factor in doing meritorious

another thirty-three years and his old age in the last thirty-three years. Or if the length of a human's life is just thirty years, the first decade is consumed by aging in just ten years, the second in the next ten years, and so on.

In the three seasons of the year, the material elements that have existed in the cold season are burnt up in four months; those of the rainy season, in four months; and those of the hot season, in four months, respectively. Of the twelve months in a year, the material elements of the first month are burnt up in thirty days; those of the second month, in thirty days; and so on. Contemplate on the burning of aging in you, in the same way, down to the shortest time span you can imagine, down to the blinking of an eye.

From the most fleeting moment to world cycles or aeons, aging is at work without interruption. Underlying it is the ultimate destroyer—death, a more terrifying fire. Aging or decay is very powerful, so you need to understand it. Unless you can perceive decay at work, you have not gained a clear perception of the causal process. You must be able to pinpoint the "culprit" of the whole scheme. So much for aging or decay. As for death and personality view, I have already explained them above.

Vicikicchā or doubt is a close associate of ignorance or delusion. Doubt is of two kinds: doubt relating to the Dhamma and doubt relating to the soul or self.

The first kind of doubt springs from the ignorance that misconceives things such as the aggregates, sense bases, and elements making up a being. A traveller in unfamiliar terrain, having lost his bearings, thinks that the right way is wrong. He is confused and cannot decide which is the right way. Likewise, due to ignorance, one does not know the earth as the earth element. Doubt makes one vacillate concerning the truth, it also dampens one's fervour to continue in the search for truth. This is doubt about the Dhamma.

The second kind of doubt arises from attachment to the notion of a vague "self" or "soul." One unskilled in dependent origination is upset when faced with death. One is shocked at the prospect of losing the present life, which one believes is one's own. One who holds wrong views dreads that after death his or her "self" may be lost for ever. One who holds right view

exists only when aging and death can arise no more. Then, and only then, is happiness real and true. That happiness is called deliverance or "escape" *(nissaraṇa)*—the seventh aspect we discussed above.

The Two Highways

There are two highways. One highway leads to the truth of suffering, the other leads to the truth of happiness.

Consider whether it is knowledge or ignorance that governs the daily activities of most beings. If their activities are undertaken with right view according to the sevenfold proficiency in the seven aspects discussed above, it depends on knowledge. Knowledge consists of acquiring insight into the elements of extension, cohesion, heat, and motion. Ignorance consists in the inherent darkness in one's mind that has kept one from perceiving the true nature of the four elements. It is the dense darkness that has been with all beings throughout the beginningless cycle of saṃsāra. All activities done under the spell of that darkness, whether they are daily chores, the religious practices of a bhikkhu, deeds of merit such as giving, haphazard mental development or learning the scriptures—in short, all undertakings, good or bad—are only acts dominated by ignorance. All actions done with ignorance lead to suffering. They make up the high road to suffering, which has been laid down under the supervision of aging and death since the dawn of time.

Ignorance is not something that needs to be cultivated. This veil of darkness has always been inherent in living beings. Knowledge, on the other hand, is something that has to be cultivated. This is possible only by following the Buddha's teaching. This is an uphill task since it entails eradicating ignorance. Knowledge is the highway where aging and death are completely absent. It is the road taken by the Buddhas, Solitary Buddhas, and all the Arahants who have ever attained enlightenment. It is the road to deliverance.

This is the exposition of the way leading to suffering and the way leading to happiness—the two highways that lead in opposite directions.

CHAPTER TEN

AN EXHORTATION REGARDING GREAT OPPORTUNITIES

1. The Great Opportunity of Human Rebirth

Why is it such a great opportunity to be born as a human being? Is it because as a human being one is free from the lower realms of misery? Is it because human pleasures are really great? No, not at all. If sensual pleasures are regarded as great opportunities, then human pleasures are nothing compared to the celestial pleasures of the heavenly realms. If pleasure were to be the criterion here, the Buddha would have mentioned birth in the heavenly realms as great opportunities. The Buddha did not do so. It should therefore be understood that by "a great opportunity" the Buddha did not mean an opportunity to enjoy pleasure, but one for doing skilful actions or meritorious deeds.

I shall amplify this statement. Merit may be done in two ways: by working for future well-being as a wealthy man or powerful deity, or by cultivating the mind for enlightenment as one of the three classes of Bodhi referred to in Chapter One. The first can be done only in the human world. The second can also be done in the human world. Many aspirants to Buddhahood have, even during the present world cycle, been reborn in the brahmā realms repeatedly. They did not, however, live out brahmā life-spans there, but willed to end their existences as brahmās by what is called "death through resolve" (*adhimutti-maraṇa*) because they were eager to fulfil the perfections in the human realm. When they were reborn as Universal Monarchs too, they renounced the world and practised the perfections.

The point is that human existence is a glorious opportunity for the wise because in one such existence innumerable good deeds can be done that can fructify as good human existences, good deva existences, and good brahmā existences.

I shall explain this point. In the human realm, the supreme glory is that of a Universal Monarch. If a Universal Monarch were to enjoy this glory to his life's end, he would lose all his glory at

is it because it provides the plinth on which the edifice of enlightenment is to be built?

Ordinary kammic merits are sought and won in all eras whether a Buddha arises or not. In the dark ages of world cycles when no Buddha arises, there are people of virtue doing meritorious deeds. Therefore, the world abounds with devas and brahmās at those times too. However, the thirty-seven factors of enlightenment are known only when the Buddha's teaching is still extant. That is why encountering a Buddha, or to be living while a Buddha's teaching is still extant, is the greatest of opportunities.

Much has been made of certain virtuous people born with a penchant for knowledge, but such mundane wisdom is superficial. It does not develop into supramundane wisdom. It cannot withstand the onslaught of non-Buddhist or wrong beliefs once the Buddha's teaching has disappeared. The once wise man then reverts to being a great person, content to drift and sink in the ocean of saṃsāra, ever seeking sensual existences like an old ghost wailing for crumbs around a rubbish heap.

> That is why the wise man, seeing clearly the benefits in maturing the perfections, and recognizing the precious opportunity that leads to enlightenment, should exert earnestly after the essential teaching of the Buddha contained in the thirty-seven factors of enlightenment.

3. The Great Opportunity of Becoming a Bhikkhu

There are three types of renunciation for the life of a bhikkhu: renunciation through wisdom *(paññā pabbajjita)*, renunciation through confidence *(saddhā pabbajjita)* and renunciation through fear *(bhayā pabbajjita)*. Of these, the first two require previous accumulations of merit or perfections. The last means taking up the life of a bhikkhu out of expediency: to seek political asylum, to recover from sickness, to take refuge from an enemy, or to avoid the struggles of the worldly life. It will be seen that the teaching of the all-knowing Buddha is the business of the wise. Whether one is a bhikkhu or a layman, the teaching is cherished only among the wise. As the saying goes, "Lions' fat collects only in a gold cup." I shall enlarge on this.

Three Gems, which implies an abiding confidence in the merit of good deeds.

4. *Adhigama saddhā* is the confidence nurtured by the Noble One who, having won the fruits of path knowledge, has realized nibbāna.

Of these four classes, even the first is a rare gift. Many who are born in Buddhist countries do not have even this kind of confidence.

One who has the second kind of confidence can revere a bhikkhu whose conduct is far from being correct, knowing the nine attributes of the Ariya Saṅgha to which a bhikkhu belongs.

One endowed with *āgama saddhā* cannot refrain from doing some sort of perfect merit even for a day.

The Noble Ones, who have won attainments in the path knowledges, are endowed with a confidence that is a great attainment *(adhigama)*. They have an abiding confidence in the Three Gems, the upkeep of the five precepts, the performance of the ten kinds of meritorious deeds, and the practice of the thirty-seven factors of enlightenment.

Confidence is a key factor that determines the extent of one's realization of nibbāna. For example, an epileptic has a fit when he hears exciting music. When he is cured of the disease, no music, however exciting, can cause a fit. He remembers how, when he had the affliction, he used to have fits on such occasions, how his heart would throb uncontrollably, how he would lose consciousness. Now that he is completely cured, he feels very glad. On seeing other epileptics suffer the same painful experience at the sound of exciting music too, he would remember his previous affliction and feel very glad in the knowledge that he is now free from it. When he hears of any cases of fits suffered by other epileptics, he feels very glad that he is free of the disease.

In much the same way, the world is filled with occasions for passion to arise, or for hatred, vanity, delusion, pride, etc., to arise. A Noble One, on coming across such occasions, remembers how in the past, before realizing nibbāna, he or she had let passion or hatred arise, but knows now that no kind of passion, hatred, or vanity can arise.

> "O how happy we are in maintaining our lives,
> Indifferent to sensual pleasures, amidst those who strive for them.
> Amidst those striving for sensual pleasures,
> We live without striving for them." (Dhp 199)

On seeing miserable people such as the blind, deaf, dumb, the insane, or wretched beings such as animals; or on pondering over the worse miseries of the lower realms, a wise person will feel worried at the thought that one of these days he or she too might very well share that fate, for he or she has been carrying on the same vain and fruitless activities prompted by the same defilements.

A Noble One, however, while pitying the sufferers, will exult in the knowledge of being free from such a fate. This kind of exultation must have been in the benign smile of Venerable Moggallāna who saw a group of petas on Mount Gijjhakuṭa. This is how a person who has quelled the passions within feels joy at the prospect of the dreary process of psychophysical phenomena soon being extinguished.

This great opportunity of living in the era of the Buddha's teaching is the time for quenching the fires within. This is the opportune moment to extinguish the eleven fires that have been burning since time immemorial. It is the time to leave behind human affairs and cares, and to devote oneself to the eradication of ignorance. Human welfare has been enjoyed often enough throughout saṃsāra; this life is not exceptional. Whether one is a billionaire or an emperor, one's riches and prestige are well worth forsaking in the quest for enlightenment. Even if one is a deva or a brahmā, these exalted existences are useless when the fires of aging and death are still burning within. All forms of worldly pleasures, whether those of kings, devas, or brahmās, are sources of defilements that stimulate the process of rebirth. As such, no pleasure is particularly worthwhile, as all are decaying, crumbling, and perishing incessantly. The only worthwhile task to set oneself is to root out the pernicious wrong view of personality, an illusion that does not actually exist. This task must be taken up at the right time which is *now*. Once the moment is past, the chance is lost!

LIFE SKETCH OF THE LEDI SAYĀDAW

The author of this manual, the Venerable Ledi Sayādaw of Burma, was one of the outstanding Buddhist scholars and writers of this age. His numerous writings show not only his vast store of learning, of which he had a ready command, but also a deep penetration of the respective subjects derived from his meditative experience. During a long period of his later life he used to spend six months of the year teaching, preaching, and writing, and the other six months meditating.

He was born in 1846 at a village in the Shwebo District of Burma. Early in life he was ordained a novice (*sāmaṇera*) and at the age of twenty he received the higher ordination with the name Bhikkhu Ñāṇa. He received his monastic education under various teachers and later studied Buddhist literature under the Venerable San-kyaung Sayādaw in one of the large monastic colleges at Mandalay. He was a very bright student. His first book, *Pāramī Dīpanī (Manual of the Perfections)* was published fourteen years after his higher ordination while he was still at San-kyaung Monastery. It was based on twenty questions set by his teacher, which he alone among the numerous pupils had been able to answer fully and satisfactorily.

During the reign of King Theebaw he became a Pali lecturer at Mahā Jotikārāma Monastery in Mandalay. One year after the capture of King, in 1887, he moved to a place to the north of Monywa town where he established a monastery under the name of Ledi-tawya Monastery, from which he derived the name Ledi Sayādaw under which he became widely known. In later years, he regularly toured many parts of Burma, teaching and preaching, and establishing Abhidhamma classes and meditation centres. He composed Abhidhamma rhymes (*abhidhamma-saṅkhitta*) and taught them to his Abhidhamma classes. Some of the Ledi meditation centres still exist and are still famous in the country.

He was awarded the title Agga-Mahāpaṇḍita by the Government of India in 1911. Later the University of Rangoon conferred on him the title D. Litt. (*honoris causa*). In later years he lived at Pyinma where he died in 1923, aged 77.

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